Exposition

ISSUE 19 The Magazine that Bridges Management & IT

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-Dian Gomes

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> "We build upon the legacy"

As we embark on the journey of Exposition Issue 19, we find ourselves standing at the intersection of innovation and tradition, ready to delve into the ever-evolving landscape of digital transformation. The vision of being a thought leader in this era of change continues to drive us, and we are thrilled to present you with a magazine that encapsulates the spirit of progress and exploration. The Exposition team recognizes the importance of undergraduates not just in academics but also in shaping the future and breaking barriers, aiming to showcase the brilliance and versatility of MIT undergraduates.

A heartfelt thank you goes out to all those who have been instrumental in making this edition possible. The unwavering support and guidance from the academic and non-academic staff of the Department of Industrial Management, the contributions of our esteemed colleagues, and the wisdom shared by IM alumni have been invaluable.

We build upon the legacy of those who preceded us, and we express our gratitude to the previous Exposition teams for laying the foundation and nurturing the legacy that we proudly carry forward. The collaborative efforts of the Exposition community, from interviewees to industry associations, have shaped this magazine into a reservoir of knowledge and inspiration.

While continuing "Edify," the Inter-University Article Competition and the Intra-Departmental Article Competition, we reboot Exposition Entrepreneurial Community (EEC) which stands as a dynamic platform, fostering meaningful interactions among the Department of Industrial Management, Entrepreneurs, and seasoned Industrial Experts.

Moreover, we are thrilled to announce the inclusion of Industrial Week with Exposition Magazine Launch, which promises an array, of engaging workshops, interview opportunities, educational seminars and culminates in a vibrant Career Fair. As the team Exposition, we are dedicated to advancing our platform, taking yet another step forward to enrich the experience for our audience.

Exposition Issue 19 is a comprehensive guide for the Department of Industrial Management, presenting innovative ideas, and insightful perspectives on digital transformation. Thank you for being a part of Exposition journey. We sincerely hope that you find Exposition Issue 19 both enlightening and inspiring.

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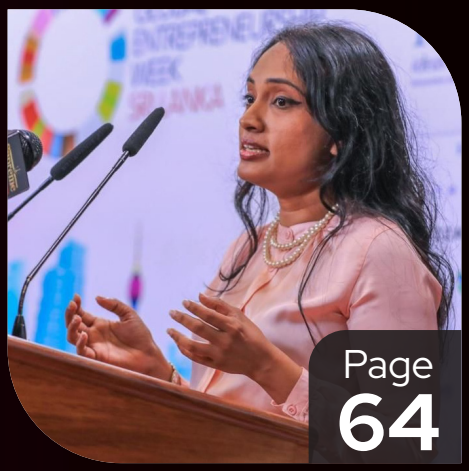
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Continuing the Legacy of Excellence

IMSSA Term 23/24

The Industrial Management Science Students' Association, commonly known as IMSSA, serves as the pre-eminent student body of the Department of Industrial Management, University of Kelaniya. Its impact extends far beyond the boundaries, with its primary focus on fostering purposeful growth among its members.

IMSSA's significant achievements lie in the three signature events, hackX, hackX Jr., and Exposition. These events have become known for innovation and industry exposure for decades, elevating the organization's reputation to new heights.

In the latest term, IMSSA has explored new territories by collaborating with both local and global tech giants and corporate leaders. This strategic move, coupled with public relations initiatives and creative marketing campaigns with some of the reputed mass media companies, has notably driven the association towards greater success.

Continuous efforts have been made to create a familial atmosphere for the undergraduates to learn and grow, building a supportive environment through engaging sessions, entertainment, and other pursuits. InfoStudio sessions series which was initially introduced with the concept of Ted -Talks, has also undergone a transformation, giving it a renewed identity.

Furthermore, the incorporation of a Career Fair into Exposition magazine launch, expanding it into the Exposition Industrial Week, has proven to enhance the brand value of IMSSA, parallelly presenting worthwhile offerings for the students to establish direct coordination with reputable companies in the industry.

These avant-garde initiatives collectively contribute to strengthening IMSSA's position as a trendsetter in the academic arena.

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University of Kelaniya

Self-purification is by insight

The University of Kelaniya is a distinguished state university in Sri Lanka, located in the Kelaniya Dalugama area, which is approximately 8 kilometers north of Colombo along the Colombo-Kandy Road. Driven by a compelling vision, the University of Kelaniya strives to emerge as a center for generating and sharing knowledge for sustainable development. Its mission is to foster intellectual citizens through creativity and innovation, making significant contributions to national development.

Today, the University of Kelaniya has evolved into a comprehensive educational institution with faculties covering Science, Humanities, Social Sciences, Medicine, Postgraduate Studies, Commerce and Management Studies, and Computing and Technology. The university offers a welcoming and inclusive learning atmosphere.

With its 55 departments, it is a representation of academic excellence. Further enhancing its educational landscape, the university hosts 27 non-degree granting educational units and centers. These specialized learning experiences offer students research, skill development, and practical application opportunities. As we reflect on the journey from Vidyalankara Pirivena to the University of Kelaniya, it becomes evident that this university is not merely a seat of learning; it is a dynamic entity,

Photo credits: Zac Jehan Photography

Department of Industrial Management

Steeped in history since its establishment in 1967, the Department of Industrial Management in the Faculty of Science, University of Kelaniya has emerged as a pioneering force, reshaping the academic landscape of Sri Lanka. Uniquely focused on imparting both Management and IT expertise to science students, the department aims to transform them into versatile professionals. Offering two distinguished degrees, the B.Sc. (Hons.) in Management and Information Technology (MIT) and the B.Sc.(Hons.) in Information Technology (IT), the curriculum extends beyond theory, emphasizing the cultivation of essential soft skills crucial for success in the professional world.

The degree program accommodates both the biological and physical science streams students. To qualify, they must pass an aptitude test and surpass the specified z-score threshold. Each year, approximately 120 students are granted the opportunity to join this exceptional scholastic approach towards education, this department stands as a dynamic hub, where scientific acumen converges seamlessly with managerial prowess to prepare graduates for a future defined by innovation and adaptability.

Delving deeper into the realm of academic excellence, the department invites those eager to reach advanced qualifications with its enticing offerings; the Master of Information Technology and the Master of Data Analytics.

The Department of Industrial Management is a leading hub for Management and Information Technology. With state-of-the-art facilities and a global tech library, it provides an ideal environment for aspiring minds where innovation and education blend seamlessly. Beyond being an educational institution, it serves as a dynamic ecosystem fostering an atmosphere where proficiency is an inevitable outcome.

Celebrating a triumphant journey towards success, the Department of Industrial Management proudly clinched the ISO 9001:2015 Quality Management System Certificate in 2020 for the remarkable third consecutive time. Beyond all these achievements, the overall acknowledgement symbolizes a commitment to the highest standards, ensuring that the department not only meets but exceeds expectations in its pursuit of prosperity and ongoing improvement.

"57 Years of Excellence"

MIT/IT

Management & Information Technology

The Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya has taken a proactive step to bridge the gap between academia and the professional world with its innovative B.Sc. (Hons.) in Management and Information Technology programme. This four-year course empowers students with a powerful blend of management and IT skills, preparing them for success in today's dynamic business landscape.

Beyond imparting theoretical knowledge, the program emphasizes soft skills and personality development, equipping graduates with the adaptability and interpersonal skills essential for professional excellence. A six-month internship opportunity further enhances practical experience, allowing students to apply their knowledge in real-world settings.

In the third year, students embark on a specialization journey, choosing from three exciting tracks: Business Systems Engineering, Information Systems, or Operations and Supply Chain Management. This tailored approach aligns their expertise with their aspirations, shaping them into well-rounded professionals

For those with a deep-rooted passion for Information Technology, the department offers a dedicated B.Sc.(Hons.) Information Technology degree programme, from 2019. This focused program equips students with the essential competencies to navigate the ever-evolving IT industry.

Adhering to the latest guidelines set by renowned professional bodies, the curriculum ensures graduates are prepared to thrive in their chosen fields, whether it's Software Engineering, IoT Engineering, DevOps Engineering, Security Engineering, Data Engineering, or Data Science.

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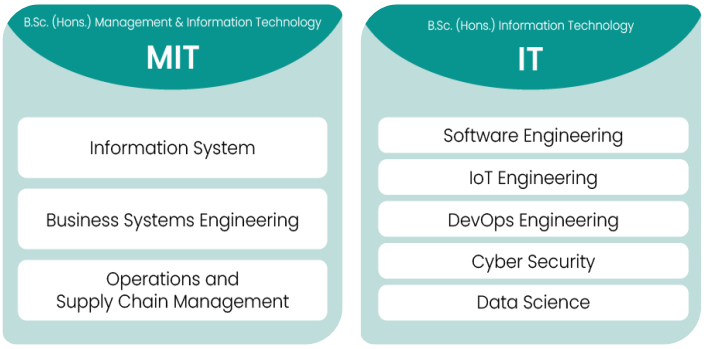

The unique fusion of Management and Information Technology provides graduates with a competitive edge in the job market. Renowned for their versatility and adaptability, they are highly sought after by employers across various industries. This blend of expertise empowers graduates to scale the career ladder with ease, leaving an indelible mark on their professional journey.

With its emphasis on empowering students to set their own goals and discover a brighter future, this program is poised to revolutionize the landscape of higher education. If you're ready to bridge the gap between academia and the professional world, this could be the perfect opportunity to embark on a transformative educational journey.

Are We Ready For AI?

Opportunities And Threats In The Sri Lankan Context

A decade or two ago, Artificial Intelligence (AI) was fiction, but it has become a reality in a space no one thought about. With the immense use of generative AI applications, AI is having its moments. We Sri Lankans, who are in an economic crisis, would want to see how we can utilize AI to make our lives easier in the short and long term.This article looks into the areas that can be improved and what we should be more concerned with.

Considering the economic and social situation that the country is going through, it is not easy to implement AI solutions with large investments. Therefore, we need to understand the areas that can be used to implement AI in given conditions.

Agriculture

According to the Central Bank Report 2022, 27% are employed in the agriculture sector, with similar employment in the industrial sector. However, the agriculture sector only contributes 7% to the GDP, compared to 28% of the industrial sector. These statistics show how primitive the agricultural sector is in Sri Lanka. Due to its heritage and cultural reasons, it is not easy to force agricultural sector employees out of the agricultural sector. Therefore, the better option would be to extend the opportunities in agriculture towards AI in planning, forecasting, and selection.

Vietnam would be a better comparison rather than comparing Sri Lanka to India or Japan. Vietnam is implementing smart agriculture to improve its agricultural sector. According to a report by the Vietnam Ministry of Agriculture and Rural Development, adopting smart farming technologies in the country has led to an increase of up to 30% in productivity and a reduction of around 15% in production costs in 2022. However, due to many other factors, Sri Lanka is far from moving to smart agriculture. So, it would be better to choose areas like crop selection and forecasting at the initial stage for the agricultural sector.

Healthcare

Not only Sri Lanka but the entire world was shaken by the COVID-19 pandemic in the last couple of years. Sri Lanka has a better healthcare system compared to other countries, even though it has had a few hiccups over the last few years, mainly due to the economic crisis. We can take a leaf out of the Mexican healthcare sector, where Mexico is using AI to analyze data and improve health outcomes for thousands of at-risk diabetic patients. Sri Lanka has recently seen an increase in non-communicable diseases, including diabetes, cardiovascular diseases, strokes, and cancers which account for nearly 90% of the disease burden in Sri Lanka (World Bank Report). AI-related diagnostic and predictive analytics can help reduce the burden in the health sector a great deal.

Education

Generative AI applications already challenge the education sector as educators raise many questions regarding online and take-home assignments. However, there are many other areas that Sri Lanka needs to focus on. According to the Central Bank Report, the student-teacher ratio is 17 in primary and secondary education, while the indicator is around 17–18 for tertiary education. While the primary and secondary teacher indicators seem to align with international standards, there are still many complaints about the lack of teachers in rural areas, which has caused many social issues. Again, AI can focus on forecasting and planning proper distribution.

After considering the opportunities for AI in the agriculture, healthcare, and education sectors, it is essential to understand the threats that we need to address.

Unemployment

When ChatGPT creator and OpenAI CEO Sam Altman was called for a hearing at the USA Senate, many senate members raised their concerns over the increase in unemployment in the USA labour workforce. According to the senators, the USA is to lose 300,000 jobs simply because of generative AI tools alone. If a country like the USA is concerned about unemployment, a country like Sri Lanka will have to address unemployment issues and underemployment.

According to the labour market indicators released by the Central Bank in 2022, unemployment has slightly improved to 4.1 from 2021. However, the usage of AI may increase unemployment in rural areas because rural areas already suffer from a lack of technology compared to urban areas. The World Bank has already voiced concerns over whether AI could widen the gap between rich and poor countries. If this happens in Sri Lanka, there will be social issues.

Government Readiness Indicator

One of the major challenges that Sri Lanka faces is a lack of infrastructure and government support. The Sri Lankan President recently appointed a task force to improve AI in Sri Lanka to address major issues. The Oxford Insights Government AI Readiness Index 2022 has ranked 181 countries to analyze how ready the government is to implement AI in delivering public services to their citizens. This index measures 39 indicators across ten dimensions and three pillars: government, technology sector, and data and infrastructure. This index ranks Sri Lanka at 105, and sixth in South Asia, raising major concerns. In the South Asian region, only Nepal, the Maldives, and Afghanistan are behind us, showing the state of the government's support for AI. In this ranking, Sri Lanka needs major improvements in governance areas such as data protection and privacy laws, cybersecurity, the legal framework's adaptability to digital business models, ethical principles, and accountability. For example, Sri Lanka has zero marks in the areas of data protection and privacy laws, cybersecurity, and ethical principles. If Sri Lanka wants to improve on AI, the Sri Lankan government needs to implement the necessary laws.

AI is a reality and a necessity that no one can avoid. Yes, we can utilize AI to improve many sectors, including agriculture, healthcare, and education. However, before implementing technical solutions, we need to look at AI's social and legal impact. Technology can be a risk if we do not manage it.

Mr. Dinesh Asanka
Senior Lecturer
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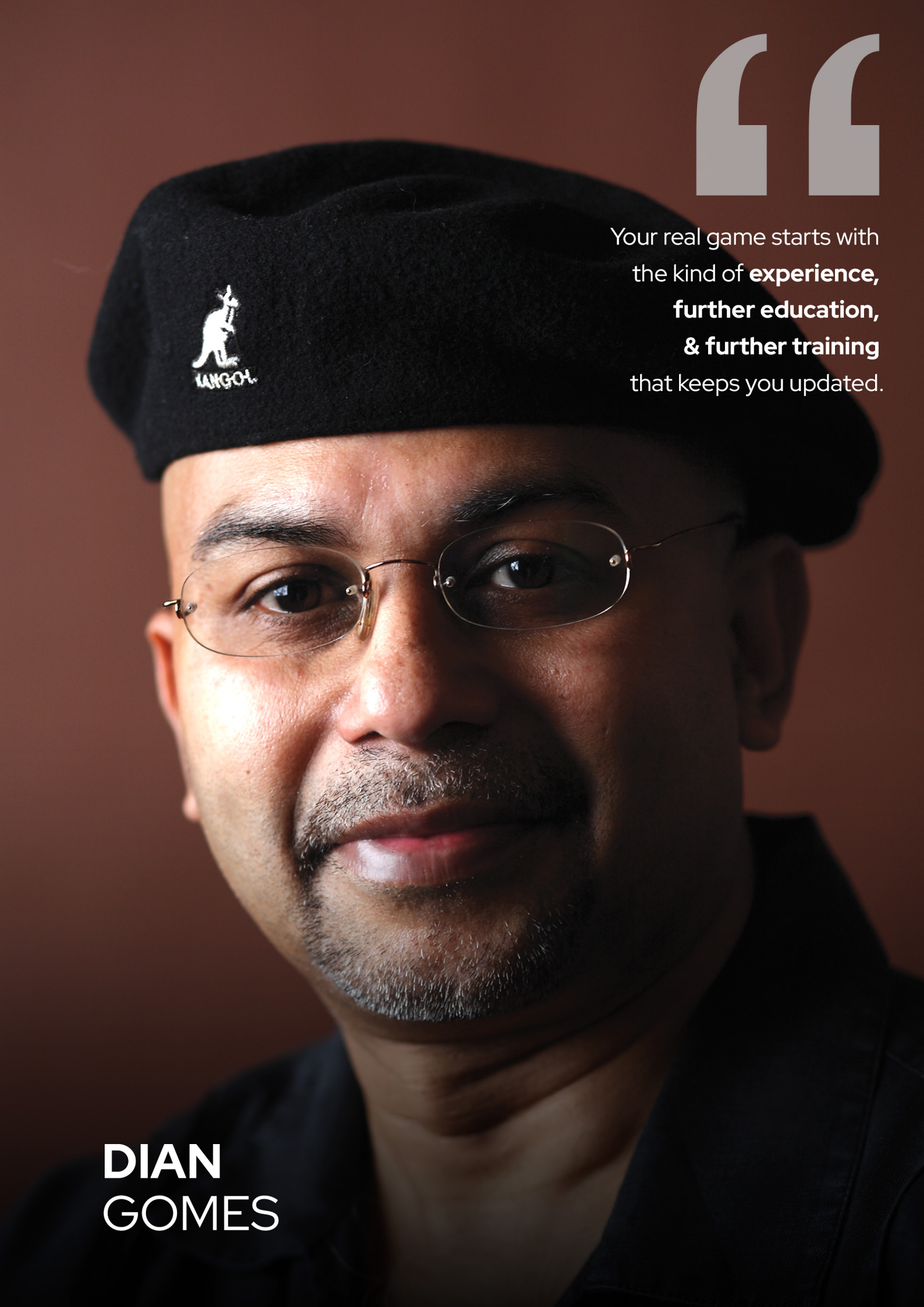


Your real game starts with the kind of **experience, further education, & further training** that keeps you updated.

DIAN
GOMES

> “Do well, change whatever you can, and give Sri Lanka a better world.”

Dian Gomes, distinguished for his outstanding leadership and academic journey at esteemed institutions such as Wharton and Harvard Business School, embodies a commitment to continuous learning. His roles at MAS Holdings underscore a leadership philosophy grounded in global exposure, networking, and people management skills, contributing significantly to the company’s impressive growth. From reshaping perceptions in the apparel industry to fostering a culture of respect, Gomes’ leadership journey reflects transformative approaches and a dedication to talent development.

Beyond his corporate endeavors, Gomes, a seasoned cornerman in Sri Lankan boxing, shares valuable insights on motivating individuals and adapting leadership styles. Advocating for a shift in the education system, he encourages undergraduates to be multi-skilled, proficient in IT, and linguistically diverse. Gomes’s advice provides a roadmap for navigating the challenges of today’s world and steering Sri Lanka toward a brighter and more prosperous future.

In addressing the challenges facing Sri Lanka, Gomes passionately advocates for a reformation in the education system, urging undergraduates to be multi-skilled and linguistically adept. His advice resonates with a call for a disciplined society committed to positive change, reflecting the wisdom gained through decades of impactful leadership across diverse sectors.

Q: You've had an extraordinary educational journey at top institutions worldwide, such as Wharton, Ashbridge, and especially Harvard Business School. How has this influenced your leadership and the key positions you hold today?

The reason is that I have a finance background. I'm a management accountant by profession. I'm an FCMA and an FCCA. But that's only the entry ticket to the game. Your real game starts with the kind of experience, further education, and further training that keep you updated. As I said, an initial degree can be from anywhere, any special thing like finance, marketing, or engineering, you name it. That gives you an entry ticket to the game in the corporate world. Then, after a few years, you do your master's or you go to a good business school and get your executive education over a period of time. Because learning is a process, it never stops.

Now, why do you need to go to a globally good university? The first thing is that it gives you networking connections. The second thing is that it gives you a global view of how things are being done, and the case studies, etc. It might be very different from the Sri Lankan environment in which you operate. But you can put it into practice what you learned at Harvard was basically the case studies on Coca-Cola and Hewlett-Packard. Even at that time, IBM, etc. How do you interpret those case studies and experiences in a local environment?

I was operating at that time as a chief executive at Slimline, at Pannala. So how do I bring those experiences to a global view, and how do you incorporate them into a local village environment?

That's the most important thing. Whether you run a large organization like MAS Holdings, with 3 billion dollars and more than 100,000 people globally, Hela Clothing, or the President of Sri Lanka Boxing, or anywhere else, it's the same concept. Basically, how you need to do that, the corporate plans, and the key performance indicators will change from industry to industry, but over a period of time, that educational background that you initially got and the subsequent education you get through good business schools will definitely help you out.

Q: Indeed, networking is crucial. How have you utilized these networking skills in your leadership roles, both nationally and internationally?

It's not only international exposure; it's even local exposure. I studied at Royal College. Of course, my academic background was more toward finance because I started as a financial controller and ended up as a finance director in a few multinational companies, then switched to general management. But I've realized over a period of time that the most important thing is your people management skills. You can be the best finance guy, or you can be a great chief executive, but without your people skills, you fail. So, the important factors and competencies that one needs to develop are leadership competencies and people management competencies. Because you can be the most brilliant guy, but you are not a research scientist when you run large corporations like MAS Holdings.

So, what is the critical factor that I need to develop? Leadership competency and managing people competence, so whatever you do, if you don't do that, you'll fail. So, when you have emotional intelligence and EQ more than IQ, I think it helps you later to network, understand people, drive people, and motivate people in any field that you want to practice. I was in apparel for a long time, but apparel and being the cornerman in Sri Lanka are two different things, but the same principle counts. When I take a guy to the corner, I've won about five world championships. 4 Asian Games, 4 Commonwealth Games, and the Olympics. I've been at the corner for many Sri Lankan boxers and thousands of fights over a period of 20 years. But how do you motivate the guy to fight for your country? In the same way, how do you motivate your employees to outperform? In all the business schools, everything will give you the theory, but you need to practice.

Q: How do you think your experiences can serve as a valuable guide for aspiring undergraduates looking to make an impactful impression on potential corporate stakeholders?

Whether it's boxing or my corporate experiences, I've given more than 800 lectures at different forums, including three times at Oxford. The most important thing that we lack as university students is challenge in the process. Because our system does not allow you to challenge, starting from school.

Then the university, then at the corporate level. That is why we have a set of followers who tend to cram the books and cram the theory. But when they get into the real world after their university degree, most of them fail. They don't do the right internships. They don't get to challenge the leadership. Say you go to Harvard Business School, and the professor who does the case study is just a peer.

You can challenge him. So, it's on an equal basis. But when I see that I do a lot of lecturing at the university level, I realize they are scared to ask questions. One is the English language. I said no; English is not a language. You can ask any question in Sinhalese, but they are nervous to ask. They want to follow the traditions.

Now you ask me one good thing: how should I call you? Mr. Gomes? or Mr. Dian? I said no, simple Dian, but people feel very uncomfortable because I am your father's age. Most probably, call me Dian. But in western society, you call your chief executive by the first name. That's what we really need to build a culture at the school level, the university level, and the corporate level to challenge the process. I'll give you a few examples. I studied at Royal College, and when I see my teachers, I stand still and call them. I don't sit and talk. Ranjan Sivaratnam, my first boss at KPMG Ford Rhodes, who passed away recently, was my mentor and my second father. We used to serve on many boards, including Nestle, and when he used to call me, though I had left KPMG a long time ago, I still stood up and answered the call because of the amount of respect and protocol that I was used to. But when I was Chief Executive at these big companies like MAS Holdings, a young Harvard graduate would tell me at the board meeting or senior meeting that you were talking bullshit and that strategy wouldn't work. I had to accept it because he is a young graduate and is much more tech-savvy.

The time I passed when I had to study computers, it was mainframe computers. Now they are of the stone age. It's no longer the IBM AS400s that we used to study. So, things have changed, and we need to change. In our university system, the student has to change. And why? Because I always tell people to come after their degree. They find it difficult to talk in English. But I always tell them, Look, "වැල්ලේ කොල්ලො ඉන්නවා German French කතාකරන." They have not even gone to school. Our laborers go to Korea, and they learn Korean; our medical students go to China and learn Chinese; and they learn Russian. So why don't you practice? They are nervous. In our system, if you make a mistake, others look down on you, and that's the problem we have. We must change the mindset. We always talk about a change of mindset. We must start here in school.

Q: How does a person who starts learning English from scratch while already being highly proficient in Sinhalese end up becoming fluent in English? Do they tend to forget Sinhala if they migrate or continue to live in?

Yes, of course, both my daughters. They attended Visaka and completed their first degrees at Manchester, earning first-class honors. They then pursued their postgraduate degrees at Imperial College, where my second daughter also achieved first-class honors.

Academically, they are quite accomplished. However, my younger daughter now manages a factory with around 150 employees in Panadura-Pinwaththa. This is her business, and it requires her to communicate effectively with her workforce. She did internships and participated in summer programs at Babson and Stanford. I emphasized to her that even if you attend the best business schools, if you don't engage with the factory workers in fluent Sinhalese, understanding their daily lives and passions, you won't thrive in a factory environment. Both of my daughters are proficient in both Sinhalese and English.

I remember when I was initially nervous about speaking at public forums, so I decided to teach at the university. This was a one-way process where students took notes while I taught. The transition was challenging for me because I studied in Sinhala at Royal College and later in English. However, today, I address large audiences of 6,000 to 10,000 people in the plants, confidently using both Sinhalese and English. I used to think in English and speak in Sinhalese, but now I can switch back and forth. I recall a specific instance when I addressed a crowd of 5,000 and said, 'අපි සනත් ජයසූරිය වගේ ප්‍රතිශතයක් ගහන්න ඕන.' One of the workers, a young girl, stood up and corrected me, saying, 'සර්, ප්‍රතිශත නෙමෙයි ශතකයක් ගහන්න ඕන.' I acknowledged my mistake, as learning, whether it's a language or a challenge, requires the confidence to make mistakes.

The academic world and the real world are vastly different. In our country, which presents unique

challenges, practices, and respect vary across regions. The skills and competencies to communicate in various languages are vital, especially when our plants are spread across different locations. Even knowing a few words in the local language can make people feel comfortable, whether it's 'Alamsalekkum' in Bangladesh or 'Pasiba' in Russia. Teaching these skills at all levels is essential, as Sri Lankans are intelligent and resilient. Given the right environment and choices, any student can excel. We have 250 scientists at NASA, and our engineers and doctors perform exceptionally well in the Western world, so why aren't they doing as well here?

The answer lies in the wrong bosses, the flawed organizational culture, the university system, and the education system that hinder students. You're certainly competent enough to be a Harvard student, and I'm confident you'll thrive there. Adapting is something Sri Lankans excel at. So, why not change the system? It may be met with initial resistance and challenges, much like when confronting corruption in boxing, but doing the right thing is worth it.

Q: Have you achieved any specific accomplishments during your leadership role at MAS Holdings that have had a significant positive impact on Sri Lanka, considering the current opportunity for improvement?

When we began MAS Holdings with Chairman Deshamanaya Mahesh, whom I consider a remarkable visionary, I believe it was the most significant mission I encountered in my corporate career. This statement isn't because he was my boss, but rather because we, as a team, transformed the company from a $6 million enterprise into a $3 billion one over the 27 years I served there.

There are three crucial factors behind this success that I consider my personal achievements.

Firstly, I attracted and developed talent that surpassed my abilities. Today, all of my subordinates and personal executives, who possess university backgrounds, have attended some of the best business schools and are now managing this $3 billion conglomerate, which operates in approximately 11 countries. This, I would say, is my most substantial success: identifying promising individuals, nurturing their skills, and preparing them for leadership roles.

Secondly, my most notable contribution to the industry was reshaping the concept of "Juki Kella." When I was your age, I held radical and socially conscious beliefs. People often labeled me a "communist." But someone wrote in my book, "Cornerman," that people may think of me as a communist, but I believe I am a socially conscious individual leading a capitalist lifestyle, which I find to be true when you visit my home. What I truly aimed to change was the lack of respect for people, particularly in the apparel industry, where workers were commonly referred to as "Juki Kella" and "Babuwa." I made it my mission to completely transform this perception and instill a sense of human respect for these workers.

I built up an egalitarian culture with the staff; they called me by the first name "Dian," and I have shared meals with the workers and other staff in the canteen.

But the most important thing is that for 37 years when I was chief executive, there was not a single industrial dispute in my career. Because I was the union leader. I was their brother. I was their chief executive. And I was their father. I took that very seriously. And I think there were individual glories in winning every Sri Lankan award and a few international awards for MAS Holdings. But those I would consider nothing. It is part of a corporate career. But the most important thing is that you did something for your fellow human beings. You thought people gave them love and motivation to fight life. Those are the things I am most proud of.

Q: You took a job that is not hated or degraded by society and made it so that they are also respected; they are also welcome, so I think that's a very generous thing of you to do and also something very meaningful to them as well in their own lives because you know whatever job you do, they say that you have to love when you do it. So, I think you made a huge step for them so that they could have a very good life. Can you share insights into your leadership philosophy and explain your approach to mentoring and motivating others? I understand you've mentioned your role as a 'cornerman' in boxing, which is

crucial. How has your experience shaped your approach to leadership and mentoring over the past 27 years?

I think leadership is very situational. I'll give you two examples. When I was 40 years old, I took my senior team and some of our junior managers on an outward-bound trip, and we had to make two rafts—actually, three rafts—slimline blue, gold, and red, and we had to row. It was all made out of bamboo, and we had to row down a lake. It was as competitive as we were, and each team was trying to make it not a fun exercise but a very competitive exercise. Sri Lankans are competitive by nature, and I was in the front with one of the younger women and rowed for about 500 meters. Then I was tired, and I put my oars down. I was 40, and there were many more younger-fit sportsmen on my raft. Suren Chikera, who was at that time about 27 and studied at S. Thomas, played rugby for S. Thomas, and he was a Ruggerite, and he said either the guy in the front row or get off. I look back; I was the Chief Executive, even the HR manager, and he said yeah, the guy in front, either row or get off the boat. So, I took my oars and rowed, and, in the team debriefing, I said, Look, leadership is you go in a rowing race, the best man must take the lead. That's number one. The second thing I took was Sri Lanka's boxing cornerman. When the boxer hit down for a 3-minute fight in the first round, I had to take the gum shield, which is full of spirit and whole blood. I had to wash it, give him a little water, and put the gum shield back. I have 30 seconds to motivate him, so I have to be in his mind, so I need to know why he is fighting and what the cause is.

Whether he is fighting for the country, whether he is fighting for glory, whether he is fighting for his parents or for his girlfriend, you know what drives a man or woman. I need to know that. So, when I start mentoring or coaching sports, it's how you motivate them in a very different way. When somebody loses, how do you pick them up in corporate? It's very different. When you miss a budget, how do you handle your senior team? How do you manage the workforce? How do you tell them the good and bad news? It comes with a lot of experience, and it comes with human intelligence and empathy. You can't go to Harvard Business School and learn that. You need some real-life experiences to understand your own motivation and what you really need to do for people. So, all these factors together will make you a great mentor or a great coach.

Q: Could you elaborate on the significance of selecting the right person for the right job and how you've successfully applied this concept throughout your career? Furthermore, how do you believe Sri Lanka can adapt to and benefit from this approach, considering the unique challenges and circumstances it currently faces?

I think my biggest success or contribution to MAS Holdings was bringing good talent, and when I was like 50 years old, my senior team would have been at least 15 years old to me. Forty percent of them were very aggressive, very competitive women, and I like the very aggressive and very competitive women on my team because I am not gender biased and they are all smarter than me. I mean, the time I did my accounting was like 30 years ago. They were younger and just graduated, so they knew the systems much better. They were technically much more skilled. What they lacked was knowledge, sometimes emotional intelligence, and life experiences, which I could easily give them and easily lead them, but on a single basis, whether it was marketing, finance, IT, or strategic planning, they would beat me hands down. They are bright, young, and motivated individuals.

Why is Sri Lanka failing? Why do our corporations fail? Why is the public sector failing? The reason is that the right people don't do the right job. Look at our government. You know the man who hates sports has never done any sports; there will be few. The man who is the Minister of Finance might not know a jack shit about finance. The man who is the health minister might not be a physician or will not have a medical background. I am not saying you need to have it, but look at Singapore and look at New Zealand; they get the best brains to lead the country starting right there, but here it doesn't happen like that, whether it's in the government, whether it's in the public service, whether in government corporations it's more political.

You know, I served in the government as well. I didn't have any senior positions for a long time, but I served two years at the Public Service Commission as a director, the apex body of the civil service. I have seen that you can't change the system; you can't promote most people on merit. I struggled in boxing, so we can talk about the big picture and take the small picture to bring out the best talent in boxing. You know, I can't do that. People try to cheat. People try to go through the back door for international games even today. I can't stop it because you are a young man, and the system is corrupt.

So how do you do that? We are thinking of things like 'Aragalaya' for change, but do we change the small things? Can you stop somebody from putting dirt on the road? Can you stop somebody from putting plastic bottles at the university? But if you start somewhere doing certain things, automatically the leadership will fall in line and people will start thinking, so you must start small. If you come to my house, you can see all the trees, but you don't see my neighborhood. If you come along Byrde Place or Strafford Avenue, I planted trees ten years ago. Today, it is a beautiful place, but initially, it was very difficult to do it. The rich people want to cut down the trees, and the poor people want to grow the trees, but today the land value is skyrocketing here because it looks very recreational; why? You need to do that, university students. You are our future. So, you can mentor, you can pick the right people, but you can't do it yourself. You need to have a good team; you need a lot of followers; and if you are truthful and if your integrity is very high, I'm sure you will do well.

Q: As we approach the conclusion of our interview, I'd like to ask one final question. Reflecting on your life experiences, do you have any advice for the undergraduates at the University of Kelaniya, especially in terms of guiding this more informed and technologically advanced generation towards achieving the objectives we have for Sri Lanka?

I think my advice is to become multi-skilled. Even if you are studying languages, learn your IT skills. Number two: learn a good language. If you are good at Sinhala and English, learn another language, maybe Chinese or Hindi. That's why the world will move. Build those skills; don't waste time on politics. I was radical at your age, but it doesn't work. I've seen how socialism works and how capitalism works. I've been to Cuba a few times; I've been to Russia; I've been to China; and I've never been to the Western World. You must master your skills, but how do you create a disciplined society committed to doing good for your country? Not to make shortcuts or make money; just follow you if you do the right thing. So as younger guys think of the future, do not think radically. I was much more radical than half of these guys around here. There is no perfect world or perfect people, but if you have a fairly robust, good judicial system and good private and public systems that are stable, and if you think of the country in the next 10 years, I think we are ready to do it, and you are part of it.

Do well, change whatever you can, and give Sri Lanka a better world.

> "Leadership is like a rowing race, the best man must take the lead.

InfoStudio.

explore | enrich | empower

In the dynamic realm of corporate education, InfoStudio, an illuminating tech-talk series orchestrated by the Industrial Management Science Students' Association (IMSSA), has emerged as a beacon of knowledge and inspiration. This initiative, curated by the Department of Industrial Management, strives to uplift Sri Lankan undergraduates by providing profound insights into the spheres of Management and Information Technology.

InfoStudio

The initial session of InfoStudio for the year 2023 witnessed Mr. Nasif Nazim, Business Manager at Trident Corporation, taking the stage. His discourse delved into "Strategies for Succeeding in the Corporate Landscape and Building a Strong Professional Image." With a wealth of experience, he imparted invaluable lessons on navigating the corporate terrain and crafting an indelible professional identity.

The second session, orchestrated by Mr. Rohan Fernando, Associate Director of Acuity Technologies, unfolded a tapestry of career opportunities. Titled "Exploring Career Opportunities and Pathways in Data Technologies in Capital Markets," this session not only enlightened attendees on potential career pathways but also showcased the collaborative spirit by involving a team from Acuity Technologies. Their collective insights and speeches added substantial value to the session.

The third session, a masterclass on personal branding, was led by Prof. Ganga Hewage, Assistant Professor of Marketing at the University of Memphis, USA. As a distinguished alumni of the Department of Industrial Management, Prof. Hewage shared her expertise on "Personal Branding" empowering students to stand out in the competitive landscape. Her global perspective and academic prowess created a session that resonated with aspiring professionals.

InfoStudio's commitment to molding young minds for success in the corporate sector has been exemplified through these engaging sessions. Each installment equips undergraduates with the skills, knowledge, and capabilities crucial for thriving in the ever-evolving business landscape. As we reflect on the diverse themes covered, it becomes evident that InfoStudio not only imparts knowledge but also fosters a spirit of curiosity and resilience among future leaders.

Mr. Nasif Nazim

Business Manager
Trident Corporation

Mr. Rohan Fernando

Associate Director
Acuity Knowledge Partners

Prof. Ganga Hewage

Assistant Professor of Marketing
University of Memphis , USA

EEC

Exposition Entrepreneurial Community

The Exposition Entrepreneurial Community (EEC) is a platform designed to assist entrepreneurs from various industry sectors in Sri Lanka to share and discuss their ideas. EEC is one of the major segments of the 'Exposition' magazine, introduced by the Exposition Team, and is officially maintained by the undergraduates of the Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya.

Small-scale and medium-scale enterprises are the main stakeholders of EEC. Fresh entrepreneurs have much to gain from the experience and commitment of these entrepreneurs, and in addition, they are a source of new ideas. These entrepreneurs play a major role in the economy by contributing their skills and creating many employment opportunities for people.

EEC organizes numerous sessions about business innovation and emerging enterprises conducted by industry experts, which prove beneficial for business innovators, enterprise enthusiasts, and even undergraduates. These sessions may be the optimal source of consultation for anyone seeking information about entrepreneurship. Additionally, they provide a platform for entrepreneurs to seek support from undergraduates, particularly in areas related to Management and IT, such as website creation and technical problem-solving, data analysis, and business intelligence.

EEC PHASE 01

NEXT-GEN ENTREPRENEURS: THRIVING IN THE AGE OF GEN Z

Mr. Lahiru Perera
CEO | Xigenix

The inaugural session of EEC phase 01 was held on 23rd of December, 2023, via the Zoom platform and was orchestrated by Mr. Lahiru Perera, CEO of Xigenix. His discourse delved into "Next-Gen Entrepreneurs: Thriving in the Age of Gen Z."With a wealth of experience, he bestowed insightful strategies necessary for success in today's rapidly evolving business world. This session not only explored the dynamic landscape of entrepreneurship in today's digital era, with a particular focus on the emerging generation of Gen Z but also aimed to shed light on the benefits of embracing the entrepreneurial spirit within the context of Gen Z, paving the way for forward-thinking strategies and sustainable business ventures.

INTER - UNIVERSITY STARTUP CHALLENGE

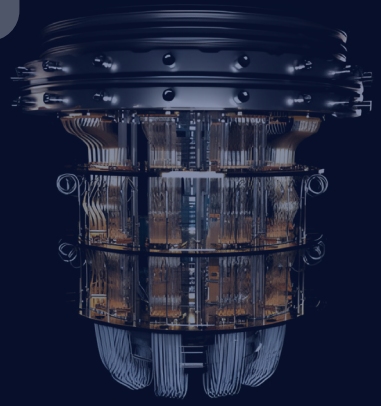
Following the success of three consecutive hackathons and four exemplary Innovative Startup Challenges, hackX 2023 is the 8th magnificent iteration of the inter-university startup challenge organized by the Industrial Management Science Students' Association. With the theme of "Sustainable Innovation," hackX 2023, the Innovative Startup Challenge will not only be limited to tech-based solutions but also be open to sustainable, eco-friendly ideas that will help ensure the existence of mankind. hackX seeks to establish a platform to expand passionate developers' innovative ideas into real-world sustainable solutions and gather recognition and support from the industry for their innovations.

hackX 2023 consisted of 3 phases: ideaX (the initial idea pitching event), designX (Startup guidance program), and hackX 2023 Grand Finals. hackX 2023 attracted over 200 proposal submissions, of which 30 were shortlisted to compete in the semi-finals. ideaX, the semi-finals of hackX 2023 was held on the 17th of September 2023 at the Department of Industrial Management. The teams got the opportunity to pitch their innovative ideas before a distinguished panel of judges, composed of Mr. Buddhika Gayan, Mr. Champika Kuruppu, Mr. Chamath Peiris, Mr. Amith Perera, Ms. Kanchana Wijethunga, Dr. Thilini Mahanama, and Mr. Buddhika Jayawardane. Based on the ingenuity of the ideas, their feasibility, and their potential, 12 teams were selected to compete at the Grand Finals. ideasprint, the intra-departmental startup challenge, was held in parallel, to select 3 teams from the Department of Industrial Management to compete at the Grand Finals.

designX comprised 4 sessions conducted to develop the skills of the finalists. Topics such as "Securing Cyber-Physical Systems", "Monetizing your unique skill set to develop and drive a successful business", "Selecting the proper technologies to transform ideas into an end product" and "Digital transformation strategies for business growth" were addressed during the sessions.

The Grand Finals of hackX 2023 was held with much grandeur on the 5th of November 2023 in the Dialog Axiata Auditorium, at Ideamart Premises. Preceded by an address from Professor Janaka Wijayanayaka, the Head of the Department of Industrial Management, the finalists took the stage and demonstrated their developed products to the judges. Team ChiMeRa of the University of Colombo School of Computing became the champions of hackX 2023 with their product "Estructura," a centralized platform that facilitates seamless interaction for professionals in the construction industry. Team Annihilators, also from the University of Colombo School of Computing, and Team IdeaLabs from the University of Sri Jayewardenepura emerged as the first and second runners-up, respectively. The three winning teams received valuable cash prizes and gifts from Trident Corporation and Creative Software. Mr. Nasif Nazim, Mr. Anuradha Rathnayake, Mr. Chamath Peiris, Mr. Issak Mohamed Infaaz, and Dr. Chathura Rajapakse, composed the honorable panel of judges at the Grand Finals. Corporate partnership representatives, lecturers, and undergraduates also added colors to the event.

Team Idea Pioneers from the University of Kelaniya emerged as the Most Popular Team and received valuable gifts from Ideamart. Special recognition deserves by the official partners of hackX 2023, whose contributions led to the success of the event: Title partner Trident Corporation in collaboration with Microsoft and Lenovo; Platinum partner Trident CSP; Gold partner Evonsys; Silver partner Creative Software; Official Ecosystem Partner Ideamart; Official Mentoring Partner 99x; Official Strategic Partner Virtusa; Official Knowledge Partner Loons Lab; and, National Partner Information and Communication Technology Agency of Sri Lanka (ICTA).



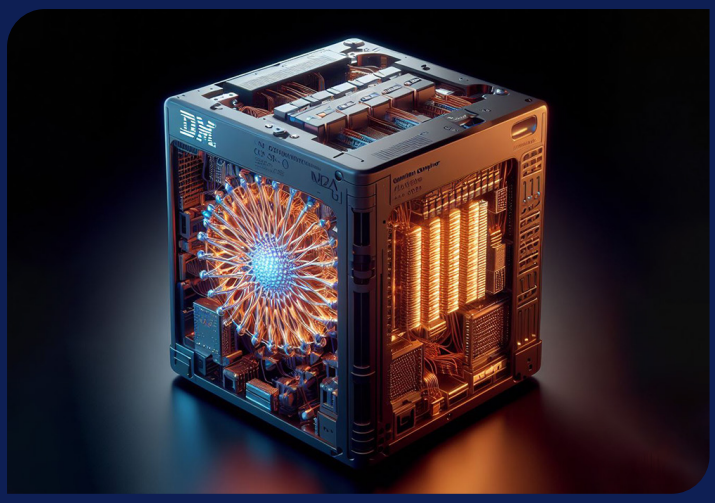
Quantum computing

By Kushani Apsara
Level 01

Imagine a world where computers are not just faster but operate in a completely different way—that's the promise of quantum computing. In the annals of technological evolution, there is no such advancement as quantum computing. We can solve many complex problems with this interesting field that intersects quantum physics and computer science. In this article, we will dive into the world of quantum computing, exploring its foundational principles, current advancements, and the myriad of possibilities it unlocks for the future.

At first, though there were only a few transistors in computers, nowadays it has increased to billions of transistors. The processing power of a computer increases when the number of transistors increases. According to Moore's law, the number of transistors in an integrated circuit (IC) doubles every two years. When the number of transistors increases in unit density, we have to reduce the size of a transistor. When the transistor size decreases gradually, electrons start to show quantum features, according to quantum physics. Quantum tunneling is such a phenomenon. It is a phenomenon where particles, like electrons, can pass through barriers they should not be able to. This happens because, on the tiny quantum scale, particles have a probability of being in different places at the same time. Quantum tunneling has practical applications in electronics, like making transistors work, but it's a strange and fundamental aspect of quantum physics. Though the technology has developed enough to make a transistor very small, it is useless to do such a thing as it takes on this quantum feature. As we can't decrease the size of a transistor further, the best thing we have to do is use the quantum features of these small particles, like electrons, to make computers. So, with this idea, the birth of quantum computing happened.

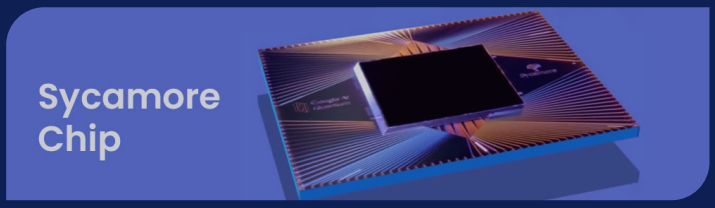
> **Unleashing the Potential of the QUANTUM FRONTIER**



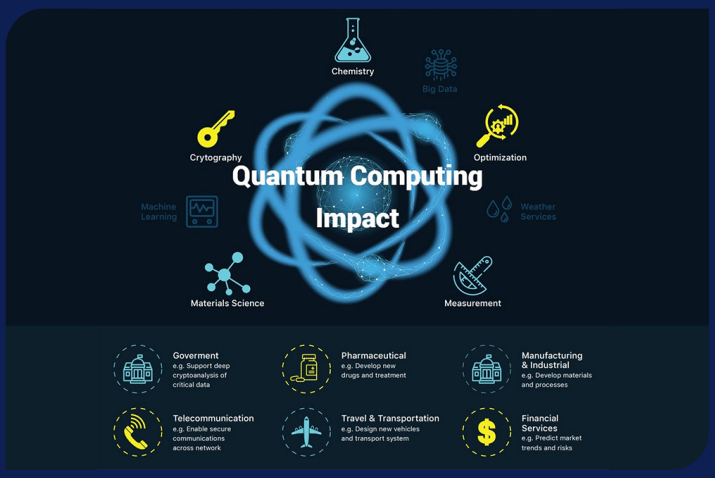
Quantum computing is a multidisciplinary field that utilizes quantum mechanics to solve complex problems faster than classical computers. Classical computers work with bits, and there can be two states, 1 (+5V) and 0 (0V), to store the binary units of information. They are known as classical bits. Quantum computers use Q bits (Quantum bits), and they also work with 1 and 0, but differently than classical computers. They use a quantum particle as a Q bit (usually using an electron). Quantum particles represent 1 and 0 according to the spin direction of the electron.

Quantum bits can exist in a superposition of states, representing 0, 1, or any quantum combination of both simultaneously. We can't say accurately about the existence and behavior of the electrons in this state. The electron can keep both spin up and spin down stages at once in this state. If we measure this, it collapses into spin-up or spin-down. As an example, if we toss a coin, we can't identify which side is up until we catch the coin in our hand. This unique property allows quantum computers to perform certain calculations exponentially faster than their classical counterparts. Another property is quantum entanglement. If entanglement occurs between two particles, they do not act as two separate particles thereafter. The state of one particle depends on the state of another particle. This property is also used in quantum computing. And this bond never breaks down, whether two particles are in two corners of the space.

Solving complex problems that are practically unachievable for classical computers in a matter of seconds is the main aim of quantum computing. Algorithms like Shor's and Grover's have demonstrated how quantum computers can factor in large numbers and search unsorted databases exponentially faster than classical algorithms. For instance, Shor's algorithm threatens the security of widely used encryption methods, making quantum-resistant encryption a necessity in the future. To make quantum computing a reality, scientists and engineers are working diligently to develop the hardware and software infrastructure necessary to harness the power of qubits. Several approaches are being explored, including superconducting qubits, trapped ions, and topological qubits. Each approach has its own unique advantages and challenges, but all share the goal of creating stable, scalable quantum systems. Superconducting qubits rely on tiny circuits cooled to extremely low temperatures to achieve a state of superposition. Companies like IBM and Google have made significant strides in developing superconducting qubit-based quantum processors, with Google's "Sycamore" processor famously claiming quantum supremacy. Trapped ions, on the other hand, use precisely controlled ions to represent qubits. These systems have the advantage of long qubit coherence times, making them suitable for error-corrected quantum computation. Companies like IonQ have pioneered trapped-ion quantum computers. Topological qubits are a more recent entrant in the quantum computing race. They rely on exotic states of matter called topological matter to encode qubits, offering robustness against certain types of errors. Microsoft's Station Q is one of the pioneers in developing topological qubits.



Quantum computing has the potential to bring about transformative changes across various industries. It can enhance cybersecurity by breaking traditional encryption methods while offering new, quantum-resistant cryptographic solutions to safeguard sensitive data. In fields such as logistics, finance, and supply chain management, quantum computers excel at tackling complex problems. Moreover, they accelerate drug discovery by precisely simulating molecular interactions, pave the way for innovative materials in electronics and energy storage through materials science, and promise to revolutionize artificial intelligence by enabling more efficient machine learning and tackling complex AI challenges. In essence, quantum computing emerges as a powerful tool with wide-ranging applications across multiple domains, promising advancements and efficiencies previously thought unattainable.



Despite its promise, quantum computing has some tough hurdles to clear. Quantum systems are super sensitive, and even tiny disturbances can mess up their operation, a problem called decoherence. Researchers are trying hard to fix this with error correction techniques, but we're still a long way from having super-stable quantum computers. Plus, these machines need to be super cold, even colder than the space between stars, which is tricky. And building and maintaining quantum hardware is expensive, which adds another challenge to the mix. So, while quantum computing has amazing potential, there are still some big obstacles to overcome.

Despite the obstacles, the quantum computing field is experiencing rapid progress. As the hardware becomes more robust, the software ecosystem is also evolving to support quantum programming languages and tools. Initiatives like IBM's Qiskit and Google's Cirq are democratizing access to quantum computing resources. Experts predict that practical and commercially viable quantum computers may still be years or even decades away, but the possibilities they present are already transforming industries and pushing the boundaries of human knowledge.

In the world of technology, quantum computing is like a shining light of hope and innovation. It has the incredible power to solve tough problems, like making our digital world more secure or speeding up the discovery of new drugs and materials. Even though there are challenges, we're moving forward with determination, and quantum computing will be a key player in shaping the future of technology. We're on the brink of a quantum revolution that will change our world in ways we can't even fully imagine yet.

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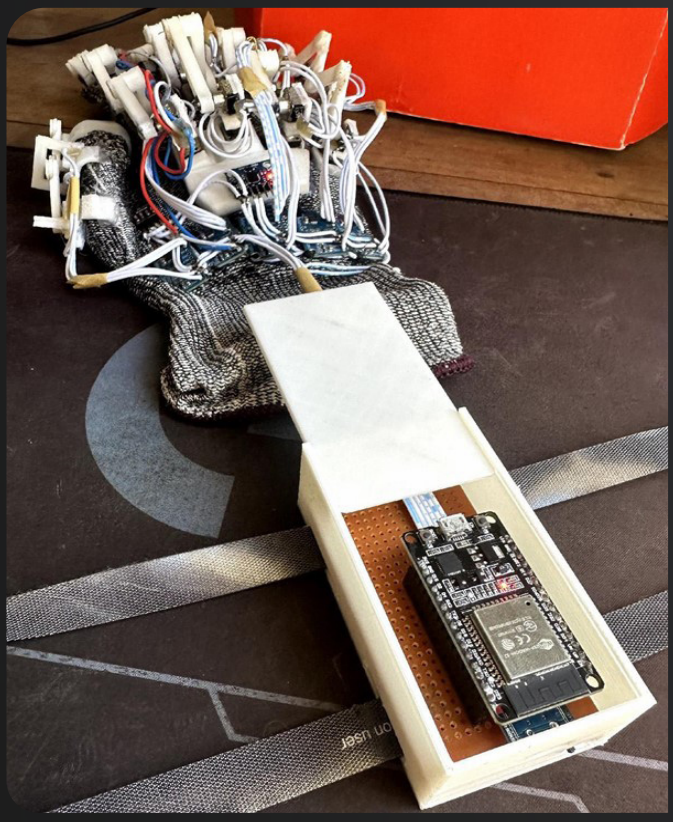

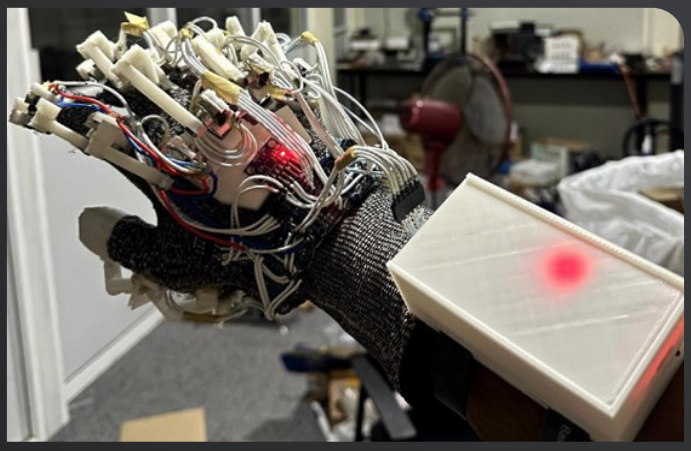

With the intention of developing myself into a professional, I enrolled in the Bachelor of Science in Management and Information Technology degree programme at the Department of Industrial Management in 2019.

I was lucky enough to grow under such a supportive, passionate departmental culture and learning environment. The introduction we received from past MIT students was priceless because they always advised and encouraged us as we chose the learning paths that would gradually improve our professional aspirations. Additionally, the department didn't think twice about setting up new learning possibilities on well-known websites like Coursera, edX, and Udemy. Undergraduates have the chance to plan a variety of events with the help of commercial organizations. Being one of the Chief Coordinators of hackX 2020, I was able to organize the event with the hackX team as a startup incubation program that was accepted

We first learned about "Embedded Systems" from Dr. Keerthi Wijayasiriwardhane as a module in the third year. This was one of the factors that led to a shift in my understanding of what information technology means to me. I was able to get an idea of complex hardware programming projects. In my last year, I used this experience to do extremely cutting-edge research to interpret Sinhala Sign Language (SSL) using a wearable sensor-based inexpensive glove. The directions given by Dr. Shantha Jayalal and Dr. Keerthi Wijayasiriwardhane were extremely important for the completion of the study.

Dr. Keerthi Wijayasiriwardhane came up with the research idea because he wanted to offer a better means of bridging the gap between the deaf/mute community and the mainstream community in Sri Lanka. Along the way of my research, I also had firsthand experience with the dedication and commitment a teacher would have to a student's achievement. They spent a lot of time describing

pirits

things like how I should overcome various challenges, different IoT device possibilities, what to do at each stage of the research, and many other things. In the end, we were able to develop,

- A firmware for the ESP32 to detect hand gestures using Arduino.
- A custom 3D-printed glove to detect hand movement using SolidWorks.
- A gesture recognition Machine Learning (ML) model using Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) to detect gesture patterns.

When we first had the idea, we decided to use flex sensors, but due to inflation at the time, each sensor was going to cost roughly 5,000 rupees. We had to add six flex sensors to each hand, which quickly increased the price of the glove. However, since the Sri Lankan economy was part of our objective, we chose to use potentiometers and specially designed 3D-printed parts. This significantly reduced the cost.

We designed holders to place potentiometers that can detect the finger bend and finger twist and identify the rotation of the hand using an MPU 6050, while a 2000 mAh battery powered the sensor glove. We created a battery container that can be fastened to the hand with Velcro. The ESP32's Bluetooth serial was used to transmit the sensor data collection to the PC. In our initial testing, which involved six gestures, the glove was 84% accurate. Additionally, we were able to detect a gesture in less than 320 ms. We were able to achieve results close to 90% as we enhanced the data gathering technique, model training algorithm, and recognition algorithm.

Also, we would like to acknowledge the invaluable support provided by Mr. Pasan Dharmasiri, the founder and CEO of PLD Industries, in helping with the design and development of this hand gesture recognition glove, and Ms. Rameela Yaddehige (a former MITian), for inspiring me to follow a path which includes IoT and embedding devices. It was the ESP32 (as a gift I received) from her that made me curious and learn about embedded systems. Also,

I am convinced that the legacy I received from this amazing institution was essential to helping me develop into a self-assured professional and that the motivation will undoubtedly help me maintain both my personal and professional lives in the future. I will always be appreciative of being a member of the IM family.

Mr. Nipuna Munasinghe

DevOps Engineer
Binary Technologies

In 2019, I commenced my MIT undergraduate journey at the University of Kelaniya and concluded my bachelor's honors degree in 2023 with a specialization in Business Systems Engineering. Throughout this period, the Department of Industrial Management (DIM) warmly welcomed me and played a pivotal role in shaping the individual I have become. The entire experience, from initiation to completion, has been a continuous journey of learning and personal growth. The support from the academic staff, non-academic staff, as well as seniors and juniors, was instrumental in successfully navigating academic challenges and participating in various extracurricular activities throughout my university life.

The COVID-19 pandemic, beginning in 2020, led to the 2nd and 3rd years requiring us to complete our academics and individual development projects entirely online. Though challenging, it turned out to be a valuable experience for us. Our lecturers made extra efforts to conduct timely exams and successfully conclude our degree programme despite the hurdles. The department provided invaluable support by offering free access to online courses on platforms like Coursera and edX during the pandemic.

I currently work in the fintech industry as a business analyst. Although it's a new industry for me, I was able to adapt to my role because of the modules offered in this degree programme. Even though I specialized in Business Systems Engineering, the department's flexibility in allowing me to take modules like Data Warehousing, Advanced Databases, and Corporate Finance paved the way for the success of my career today. I must also mention the guidance provided by my research supervisor, Prof. Annista Wijayanayake, and the research assistants from the temporary academic staff. With their support, I was able to publish three research papers within one year.

DIM is a place where everyone helps each other weave their own success stories. Our humble lecture panel always encouraged us to engage in extracurricular activities while pursuing our academics. Six months of industrial training in the 3rd year, industry visits, field visits, and knowledge-sharing sessions with reputed companies are key offerings from our department to produce industry-driven graduates. The confidence and opportunities we received to organize events like hackX, Exposition, Rasoga, and talent shows from the department are the main reasons for improving leadership skills, communication skills, and handling stressful situations effectively in both our academic and work lives.

I wholeheartedly endorse this MIT/IT degree programme for anyone considering it. DIM ranks among the top places to acquire industry-ready knowledge and experiences, providing a solid foundation for securing your dream job. It excels in nurturing not only academic prowess but also essential soft skills and a positive mindset throughout your degree journey. Seize the opportunities presented by this exceptional department to enhance your personal development and contribute to the advancement of both yourself and the nation. This encapsulates the core principles and aspirations of DIM. Cheers to the continued success of DIM!

"Once an **MIT**ian, always an **MIT**ian"

Ms. Kulesha Rashmini

Business Analyst
GTN Tech

PARTNERS

hackX 8.0 2023

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What you accomplish
today will become
history tomorrow
in this dynamic field,
therefore
persistence is esssential.
Dr. UPENDRA
PIERIS

> “I emphasize the importance of qualities such as passion, vision, goals, belief, preparation, action, and persistence.”

Dr. Upendra Pieris is a seasoned professional with an impressive track record spanning over a decade in the Information Technology, Artificial Intelligence (AI), Data Analytics, and IT industries. As the Chief Executive Officer of OREL IT, a prominent IT solutions provider based in Sri Lanka and extending its influence beyond, Dr. Pieris plays a pivotal role in steering the company towards excellence.

His academic background is marked by a significant achievement, having earned a PhD in Information Technology from the European International University. Dr. Pieris combines his extensive practical experience with a deep understanding of theoretical aspects, contributing to his leadership in the dynamic field of IT.

Dr. Pieris is not only a proficient industry leader but also an active participant in the academic and professional community. His commitment to advancing the field is demonstrated through his membership in the Sri Lanka Association for Artificial Intelligence (SLAAI), showcasing his dedication to staying at the forefront of technological advancements and contributing to the growth of AI in Sri Lanka.

We now transition to the anticipated interview segment, wherein we have the honor of engaging in a formal discourse with Dr. Upendra Pieris, the esteemed Chief Executive Officer of OREL IT.

Q: What significant factors have contributed to the formation of Dr.Upendra Pieris as the individual who is today encompassing both personal and professional dimensions?

I prefer to go by my name, so you can call me Upendra. Reflecting on my contributions from my family and extended family, I consider myself fortunate to have had the opportunities I've had.

During my time in school, I served as the sports captain, a role that provided me with valuable experience working with a diverse group of individuals. During my university years, I was deeply involved with the Sports Council, serving as an event organizer for three consecutive years, which allowed me to collaborate with numerous cohorts.

In my current role at Orel IT, the pinnacle of my career, I have had the privilege of directly engaging with over four thousand team members and a global network of over one hundred thousand employees in the Orel group. This success has allowed me to connect with a vast array of individuals, not only within my immediate family but also within my extended family, both locally and globally. That's part of the support I've received, and the other aspect involves professional engagement within the same ecosystem. This extends beyond local communities, local government, and non-governmental organizations, as I've had the opportunity to collaborate with global communities such as Forbes. My involvement with the Forbes Technological Council provided me with exposure to communities outside my home country.

Apart from that, I have been working with tech giants from Global Fortune organizations all around the world in my nearly 18 years of career life. These experiences have shaped the opportunities that have come my way up to this point.

Q: Were there any in-betweens from your university life to Orel IT?

I consider Orel to be my fourth job, coming soon after my time at the university. My first job was as a data entry operator during my second year, where I worked the night shift from seven in the evening until three in the morning. I became accustomed to this schedule, and even now I tend to sleep late, although I've also adjusted to getting up early. This has limited my sleeping time somewhat.

My second job was as a web developer, and then I transitioned to being a software developer at a startup. Thirdly, I worked in the corporate sector as an IT manager, followed by a global technology firm as a business analyst, and then as a project manager. From there, go to an NGO before joining Orel. I've now been with Orel for eleven years, I was 26 years old when I joined Orel, so that's a bit about the time between my university days and working at Orel.

Q: So, you would say you went through the tough ritual of an undergraduate to get to where you are today?

Yes, I'm also from a middle-class family. Both of my parents were attached to the Government services, my father was attached to the police and my mother was attached to the Co-operative Society.

My hometown is Kegalle; I schooled in Kegalu Maha Vidyalaya in Kegalle and did A/Levels in Maths stream. The only opportunity that I got to expose myself to the central or capital culture was that I was one of the people outside Colombo who represented the national badminton team. So, that's the only exposure I got a chance to be connected here.

Q: Can you elaborate on how your early life influenced your career choices and personality traits?

Regarding how my early life influenced my career choices and personality traits, I believe I was given numerous opportunities to take on leadership roles. I wasn't coerced into these roles but rather selected for them. During my school days, I held positions such as head prefect and was heavily involved in sports, participating in various activities like badminton, rugby, chess, basketball, and athletics. I often found myself leading different teams, a trend that continued through my university years and into my professional life, whether it was in projects or software development. This experience has ultimately led me to my current role, where I am not just leading a small team, but rather a global fraternity. This early exposure to leadership has significantly influenced my career trajectory and personal characteristics.

On the contrary, when it comes to technology, I have not been particularly attached to it. During my school years, my focus leaned more towards aesthetics. I was certified in Eastern Singing, indicating my strong interest in music. Conversely, my brother was deeply involved in technology, specifically electrical and electronics. Unfortunately, he passed away in 2001 when I was in the midst of my O/L exams. Our family had a 'Pentium 3' computer as early as 1996.

Although I was granted about two hours per week to use it for recreational purposes, it primarily belonged to my brother, who was significantly more engaged with it. Following his passing, I felt compelled to carry on with his technological pursuits, as I couldn't bear to see his interests left unattended. This transition marked a shift from my previous focus on sports and aesthetics to a greater involvement in technology.

Q: With a doctorate in Information Technology and an MBA, how have your academic pursuits shaped your approach to leading a tech-driven company?

In line with many professionals in the IT industry, my academic aspirations centered around becoming a software developer or engineer, as Industry 4.0 and AI were not yet prevalent. Early on, my focus was on pursuing a technical role in software or mobile app development. However, before completing my MBA, I pursued a PhD due to my initial pursuit of an MBA being left unfinished. As I completed my MSc, my inclination towards a technical, development-focused path remained strong, but as I progressed, I realized that advancement often leads to managerial roles, necessitating the acquisition of management skills. Consequently, at the age of 26, I unexpectedly transitioned into a managerial position, initially overseeing a team of 60 individuals, which has since expanded to over 4,500. My role has evolved into providing managerial leadership to the team, prompting me to recognize the importance of equipping myself with comprehensive managerial and administrative skills to effectively manage a team of technology professionals, rather than being content with simply assuming a managerial role.

This is one of the reasons why I continued to advance my education, which is closely connected to this aspect. However, my commitment to ongoing learning has been unwavering. Currently, I am actively seeking to deepen my understanding of meta, as it has been a topic of extensive discussion among my peers.

Initially, I was uncertain about how to approach it, and a year ago, I even suggested that we avoid getting involved because I suspected misinformation. However, I have come to realize the necessity of learning about it to engage in informed conversations with others.

Q: Reflecting on your career, can you recall a specific incident that served as a turning point, significantly impacting your professional trajectory?

Yes, I believe this is pertinent to the IT industry. As I mentioned, I got married at the age of 25 due in part to the passing of my brother, leaving me as the sole remaining member of my family. I felt the need to take this significant step and establish a sense of stability in my life. Shortly thereafter, I found myself heading a completely new business and team, which was a departure from the traditional operations of Orel, a company primarily known for its role in a manufacturing institution called Orange Electric. Orange Electric had not previously ventured into the realm of IT, as their focus lay in Manufacturing Engineering rather than IT Engineering or Software Engineering. Consequently, when the opportunity arose to lead the IT team as a manager, I embarked on this journey, forging new connections and engagements. Orel, as a brand, provided substantial support for this endeavor, serving as a reliable foundation, while Orange Electric continued its 95-year legacy in the manufacturing business. Furthermore, it's worth noting that Orange is widely recognized as the market leader in Sri Lanka and holds the distinction of being the country's foremost IT business exporter. From this point onward, we have become well-equipped from both perspectives: as a manufacturer and as a technology exporter. Entering Orange represented a pivotal moment as it presented a unique challenge. We encountered organizational challenges that were not previously tech-related, while simultaneously

delving into the export business.

Our focus was not centered on developing another IP primarily focused on services, but rather on the demanding role of serving as a platform or ecosystem provider. My personal growth has been closely intertwined with the company's development. At the age of 26 in 2012, our team consisted of 60 individuals, and we were solely engaged with a single customer in the service sector. Fast forward to the present, and we have evolved into a global enterprise with a presence in 32 countries, establishing partnerships, operating our own offices, and maintaining teams that contribute to comprehensive development efforts. The opportunity to grow alongside the company marked a significant turning point in my career, and I have now dedicated over 11 years to this journey, a prospect that I had never anticipated.

Q: Were there any challenges that you faced in between, like, where you thought this might not work? Were there any risks involved? But you did it anyway.

Yes, in the early stages, we faced a significant challenge when we began collaborating with an R&D team from Israel. This presented difficulties due to our unfamiliarity with the technology and our lack of experiencein working with Israeli tech teams. Communicating with Israelis, known for their direct and sometimes less diplomatic communication style, posed a challenge initially.

However, we gleaned valuable insights from this experience, and over time, they grew to appreciate our efforts in Sri Lanka. This learning process extended beyond technology into understanding people and cultures. As a result, we have developed the capability to engage effectively with teams from diverse locations, including Israel and the U.S. At that time, my team was relatively young, with members ranging from 20 to 26 years old. Although we lacked a strong business mindset initially and approached our work with considerable aggression, we gradually honed our ability to nurture and maintain business relationships as we evolved.

Q: How do you balance technical aspects with people management while promoting innovation?

Certainly, the approach I've adopted differs due to the abundance of technical individuals in my team, leading to frequent internal debates. When numerous technically proficient individuals with similar capabilities convene, I found myself adopting a different role. Rather than contributing from a technical standpoint, I assumed the role of a disruptor, challenging proposed ideas and approaches, often representing the perspective of a typical, non-technical end-user.

I firmly believe that each team should encompass this balanced dynamic. Within our internal model, we have established an innovation pipeline, we strive to maintain a composition wherein at least 50% of the team is comprised of non-IT or non-technical individuals. This deliberate mix ensures that the team is not solely dominated by technical expertise. As a proponent of the non-technical team, I aim to amplify the voice of the customer or end users, empowering my colleagues to consider these perspectives in our innovation initiatives.

I believe that this model or approach is viable and effective. Ultimately, our focus should be on the customer's perspective rather than solely on our desired developments. I believe that our current emphasis on service provision, as opposed to engaging in competition for IP development, has allowed us to support numerous global IPs worldwide. By prioritizing the end customer's viewpoint, we have been able to make our innovation efforts more pragmatic. This is a key consideration that we are currently contemplating.

Q: A more evolving and popular topic today is AI and machine learning. And they're rapidly evolving fields. So how does Orel IT stay ahead of its technological advancements and maintain its position as an innovative player in the AI industry?

Yes, we are currently implementing several strategic initiatives. Firstly, we have established global teams, not only in Sri Lanka but also in Israel. Although we initially served as a supplier for Israel, we now have an on-ground team integrated into Orel IT. Furthermore, we have formed another team that incorporates specific technologies from Dubai. In 2019, we acquired a company in the US, becoming the first Sri Lankan company to fully acquire a US entity. This team focuses primarily on Datacom and Networks and is

oriented toward the US market. Additionally, at the end of November, we are opening our center in Sweden, which will serve as our Center of Excellence (CoE). The CoE will be connected to Dubai and Sri Lanka, where we have the largest R&D teams, as well as the teams in the US and Israel. Sweden will function as our R&D services center from November onwards. Our overarching goal is to align our operations with the trajectory of our country's advancement, ensuring that we operate around the clock. We believe that by incorporating collaborative technologies, not limited to those developed solely in Sri Lanka, we can cultivate a unique position in the global industry. This collaborative approach represents one of the key strategies we are currently pursuing.

The second point is that, as the number of people in our organization grows and technology continues to evolve, it is essential to recognize that learning is an ongoing process in the tech industry. What you know today may be obsolete tomorrow. As a result, we have multiple teams supporting various cloud services. To address this need, we are establishing the Orel Academy, which was initially created to benefit our employees. The primary focus of the academy is on certifications, upskilling, and obtaining qualifications in newand emerging technologies. The program is designed with two key performance indicators (KPIs): the standard work-oriented KPI, and the KPI for advancing one's skills and knowledge in line with career goals. The academy provides tutors who ensure that individuals receive support for certification and the necessary credits. These efforts are interconnected to support the local ecosystem, both within Orel IT and across our global teams. However, we are now expanding the scope of the Orel Academy to serve as a general service, not only for Orel but also for professionals in different industries. Our aim is not to compete with educational institutions, but rather to focus on upskilling both our employees and those outside of Orel IT. To achieve this, we have already developed specific curricula with the support of various organizations, academic groups, and universities that we collaborate with. Presently, we have implemented several programs focused on AI, 3D printing, industrial applications, and data science. These programs are designed as crash courses, essentially serving as conversion programs. For instance, we offer a program to transition software engineers into AI engineers.

This is an ongoing initiative representing the future, as we anticipate that individuals currently working in software engineering will transition to become AI engineers.

Q: So earlier, you mentioned your leadership skills. So, as a leader, nurturing talent within your organization is very crucial. So how does Orel IT invest in the continuous development of its employees, especially in emerging fields like AI and Data Analytics?

The academy plays a crucial role in upskilling individuals so that our pre-programs, including internships, management training, and associate programs, prepare people to advance toward their next career milestones. This represents one aspect of our overall efforts. In addition, we are involved in several university degree programs, notably with SLIIT, and potentially with other institutions, including government entities. We provide funding for certifications and enable students to work with us in tandem with their studies.

Furthermore, we have established a partnership with the DP education team, through which we support trained AI school graduates to collaborate with us and contribute to our projects. These initiatives are integral components of our internal system. Moreover, within our internal teams, we engage with academic lecturers from universities such as Moratuwa University, SLIIT, and Colombo University for our R&D projects and industrial REIT from Orel IT. Academic representatives are involved in most projects to ensure ongoing support for the team's upskilling efforts. Consider a scenario where we are involved in a project within the medical sector that focuses on vision-based technologies. In such cases, we may have a mentor from a university who becomes an integral part of the project team. These mentors participate in briefings and share course materials, which may include white papers or existing online resources.This academic support and mentorship are integrated into our system, contributing to a continuous learning experience. Our approach emphasizes that our activities are not solely about project development,

but also about learning and growth. Furthermore, it is essential to note that we have long identified ourselves as a workplace university. This means that everything we do is oriented towards learning and development. This philosophy has been ingrained in Orel since its establishment.

Q: As undergraduates in Management and Information Technology, at the Department of Industrial and Management, we learn about Management and Information Technology. If we join Orel IT or any other industry and go through your conversion programs, how would the transition impact us? Would it be easy, or would it be like a tough conversion?

No, I don't believe it will be a challenging transition. Firstly, we are considering the current generation. Therefore, I don't foresee significant

difficulties for them in adapting to new technologies. Especially for the current generation, I don't anticipate it being a difficult task or transition for anyone. This is because they are well-equipped and already familiar with the technology landscape. Even school leavers or students in the educational system are likely to have a good understanding of the current global technology landscape, not just locally. Therefore, transitioning or embarking on a new technological journey should not pose a problem.

In the case of university students, I believe the process will be even smoother. The need for this transition has already been recognized. In the past, such opportunities were not available, and industrial training programs were not as prevalent. However, the present scenario is different, as many universities now offer such programs, some even extending to one-year programs, which I believe will provide numerous advantages. I am optimistic that local universities will also develop similar initiatives in the future.

Engaging in industry for a year while learning will significantly enhance the value of the educational system, as it allows individuals to bring industry experience into their learning process. This means that not all learning occurs after formal education, and I am confident that the transition will not be a cause for concern.

Ultimately, regardless of the technologies we employ, the fundamental concept revolves around managing information. This could involve data visualization in Data Science, Information Management, or generating relevant output from AI or models. It encompasses various systems such as CRMS, SAP, or ERPs, all of which are designed to manage the flow of information. In essence, we are discussing Information Management.

Whether an individual is a developer, analyst, or manager, the ultimate goal is to create an ecosystem that facilitates the management of information. Moreover, we recently analyzed our entire Orel group, which revealed that Orel's focus lies in power, data, and sustainability. "Power" represents our electrical arm operating under the Orange Electric flagship brand, while "data" refers to Orel's examination of how we function across the entire data ecosystem. We firmly believe that raw information, or data, plays a pivotal role in all the technologies we utilize.

Q: If you were to outline the essential elements for achieving success, what key factors or guiding principles would you emphasize?

I would define success in general terms, and for me, passion is the first key factor. Without passion for what you are doing, there is a lack of personal contribution and motivation. Secondly, even with motivation, a clear vision is essential. Therefore, I would consider vision to be the second crucial element. You need to have a clear understanding of what you want to achieve, which leads to the third point, setting goals. Establishing achievable goals that align with your vision is pivotal. It is important to believe in your goals and ensure they are practical and attainable. However, simply having goals and beliefs will not yield results unless you adequately prepare for them. Preparedness is vital. If you seek knowledge, you must actively pursue it and equip yourself accordingly. It is essential to be ready to pursue your goals. Just believing that you can climb a mountain is not enough; you need the proper equipment and training to succeed. Next comes the action phase. You may have acquired all the necessary knowledge, similar to your time in university where you grasp what needs to be achieved and learn for it, but the crucial step is putting that knowledge into practice. This is the action phase. Regardless of how well-prepared you are, unless you take action at the right moment, progress will stall.

Furthermore, persistence is key. In the ever-evolving tech industry, achieving something does not mean the journey is complete. What you accomplish today will become history tomorrow in this dynamic field. Therefore, persistence is essential; you must continue to progress and learn. In line with my definition, I emphasize the importance of qualities such as passion, vision, goals, belief, preparation, action, and persistence.

HOW YOU DID IT?

"How you did it?" is a session series designed for undergraduates to get inspiration from the journeys of successful individuals who have excelled in their careers. Now in its fourth year and ongoing throughout, this platform offers a chance to gain insights, learn from experiences, and set the stage for future career empowerment.

Episode 08 - Management or IT ?

Discover your career journey between two dominant sectors in today's industry

Ms. Ruwanthi Perera
Senior Project Coordinator
at GTN Tech

Mr. Nipuna Munasinghe
DevOps Engineer
at Binary Technologies

In Episode 08, we dived into the world of Management and IT sectors, helping MIT undergraduates navigate their goals. Led by two successful graduates,Ms.Ruwanthi Perera and Mr.Nipuna Munasinghe from the Department of Industrial Management, these sessions offered a valuable glimpse into what these sectors offer.

Episode 09 - Navigating the AI-Driven Future of IT

Discover key strategies and perspectives in this illuminating session on Artificial Intelligence.

In Episode 09, we delved into the AI-Driven Future of IT, exploring key strategies and perspectives in an illuminating session on Artificial Intelligence conducted by Mr.Arjuna Nanayakkara, Global Head of Shared Services and CEO of GTN Technologies.

Mr. Arjuna Nanayakkara
Global Head of Shared Services and
CEO of GTN Technologies

Scarcity of Entrepreneurship Disciplines in Sri Lanka

By Sanjitha Nimsara
Level 01

A Major Impediment to Economic Growth

The engine of economic development and growth is entrepreneurship. It promotes innovation, brings about new goods and services, and produces new jobs. More opportunities to improve the world as a place to live are produced through entrepreneurship. However, the lack of entrepreneurship disciplines in Sri Lanka is a significant barrier to the nation's economic progress.

What are entrepreneurship disciplines?

The body of knowledge and abilities required by entrepreneurs to launch and operate prosperous enterprises is known as the entrepreneurial discipline. Planning a business, marketing, finances, management, business administration, the economy, and sociology are some of the subjects covered by these disciplines.

Why are entrepreneurship disciplines scarce in Sri Lanka?

The dearth of entrepreneurship disciplines in Sri Lanka is caused by several issues. The absence of entrepreneurship education in schools and universities is one contributing reason. Most schools and colleges in Sri Lanka don't provide entrepreneurship courses. Therefore, students are not exposed to the information and abilities required to launch and manage their firms.

The absence of role models is another issue in Sri Lanka's shortage of entrepreneurship disciplines. In Sri Lanka, there aren't many successful business people. This is because of several things, including a dearth of entrepreneurship education and the high likelihood of failure when beginning a new business. As a result, when pursuing a career in entrepreneurship, young people in Sri Lanka do not have many role models to look up to.

Most people are content with their jobs, in large numbers. They almost feel content with what they already have and think poorly of entrepreneurship. People lack creativity. This incident may cause significant problems in Sri Lankan entrepreneurship fields.

In Sri Lanka, the lack of entrepreneurial education has several detrimental effects. It first stifles economic development and innovation. Furthermore, it raises unemployment rates, particularly for young people and it lowers Sri Lanka's competitiveness in the international market.

What can be done to address the scarcity of entrepreneurship disciplines in Sri Lanka?

There are several things that can be done to address the scarcity of entrepreneurship disciplines in Sri Lanka. One important step is to introduce entrepreneurship education at the school and university levels. This will give students the knowledge and skills they need to start and proceed with their businesses. Another important step is to create more role models for young entrepreneurs.

This can be done by highlighting the success stories of Sri Lankan entrepreneurs and by providing them with support and mentorship.

The government of Sri Lanka can also play a role in promoting entrepreneurship. The government can provide financial incentives to entrepreneurs, reduce the regulatory burden on small businesses, and create an environment that is more conducive to risk-taking.

The importance of entrepreneurship education

Entrepreneurship education is essential for entrepreneurs to acquire the knowledge and skills necessary to start and run successful businesses. Through this education, students can learn about various topics, including Business Planning, Marketing, Finance, Management, Leadership, and Innovation.

A key skill that all firms value is the ability to see issues and find solutions that lead to novel experiences and unexpected outcomes. Doubts about society and the wider world are sparked by curiosity. These kinds of questions and issues are therefore resolved by incorporating creativity. Education in entrepreneurship aids in carrying out this duty.

Entrepreneurship education can also help students to develop an entrepreneurial mindset, which is characterized by creativity, risk-taking, and perseverance. An entrepreneurial mindset allows the young generation to think differently. When learning to think like an entrepreneur, students will start to develop creative solutions to complex problems. As a result of this process, it helps to build a talented entrepreneur.

The role of role models

Entrepreneurial stories, such as the remarkable and breathtaking story about Steve Jobs, are often adopted as effective teaching material to promote individuals' entrepreneurial mindsets in entrepreneurship education. Young people need role models to inspire them to pursue careers in entrepreneurship. Young individuals are more inclined to believe that they can realize their business objectives when they observe successful entrepreneurs who have overcome obstacles and achieved their goals.

By showcasing the success stories of Sri Lankan businesspeople, the government of Sri Lanka may help develop more role models for future entrepreneurs. Young entrepreneurs can be supported and mentored by the government, which can aid in their success.

The role of government

The government of Sri Lanka can play a role in promoting entrepreneurship by providing financial incentives to entrepreneurs, reducing the regulatory burden on small businesses, and creating an environment that is more conducive to risk-taking.

For example, the government could provide tax breaks to startups or offer grants to entrepreneurs who are developing innovative products or services. The government could also reduce the number of regulations that small businesses must comply with. Sri Lankan entrepreneurs are facing various political and economic crises in the current movement. The Sri Lankan government must be involved in this subject to ensure the development of the country.

The lack of entrepreneurship disciplines in Sri Lanka must be addressed if the nation is to thrive economically. Sri Lanka can develop a more dynamic and creative economy by making investments in entrepreneurship education, fostering more role models, and offering assistance to entrepreneurs. The lack of entrepreneurship disciplines in Sri Lanka can be addressed, leading to a more innovative and affluent society for all.

Lankan entrepreneurs to inspire young people to pursue a career in entrepreneurship, reduce the regulatory burden on small businesses and create an environment that is more conducive to risk-taking. By taking these steps, Sri Lanka can create a more vibrant and innovative economy that is driven by entrepreneurs, which will ultimately benefit all Sri Lankans.

Mr. Sanjitha Nimsara
Level 01,
Department of Industrial Management,
University of Kelaniya.

GTN

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88.6 | 88.8

hackX Jr.

INTER SCHOOL HACKATHON 6.0

hackX Jr. 6.0 is the 6th consecutive iteration of the inter-school hackathon organized by the Industrial Management Science Students' Association. Fueled by the concept of "Give Shapes to Ideas", this competition offers a stage for the bright, young minds of school children to harness their capabilities and bring their ideas to life. hackX Jr. 6.0 is a competition which has also been recognized by the Ministry of Education.

hackX Jr. 6.0 consisted of four phases: Awareness Session, Online Workshops Series, InnoX - the Semi-Finals, and the Grand Finals. The awareness session was held on the 12th of September 2023, at the Auditorium of the Department of Industrial Management, Faculty of Science, University of Kelaniya. It was also streamed virtually through Zoom platform and the official Facebook page of hackX Jr. Here industry experts guided the participants through the world of hackathons, unleashing their creativity to generate groundbreaking ideas that can turn their vision into reality. The session commenced with a speech from Mr. Dushantha Ranwala, Tech Evangelist at Ideamart, Dialog Axiata PLC, setting the tone for the event. The keynote address was delivered by Mr. Dhanika Perera, Founder/CEO of Bhasha Lanka (Pvt) Ltd, who shared insights on "Unleashing Entrepreneurial Excellence: From Dreams to Reality."

Following that, Ms. Pulani Ranasinghe, Founder/CEO of Loons Lab, also an alumnus of the department, navigated the audience through "The Art of Crafting a Winning Proposal". Mr. Kithmal Warnasooriya, the Founder/CEO of Elysian Crest, discussed "Mastering Problem Identification and Validation". Lastly, Mr. Rajive Silva, CEO of Azend Technologies, covered the "Characteristics of an Innovator", with an engaging session with the students.

From over 200 proposal submissions, 25 proposals were shortlisted to compete in the Semi-Finals. Two online sessions were held to guide the semi-finalists. Mr. Varatharaja Kumaraguru, the CEO of Youth Business Sri Lanka did an inspirational session on "Ideas vs. Reality" on the 8th of October 2023 via Zoom. It was an insightful session that gave a comprehensive understanding of idea development. Also, the level-up session conducted by Mr. Mohammed Fawaz, Founder of Curve Up was held on the 22nd of October 2023, via Zoom. It was an informative session that gave a complete understanding of the Lean Canvas Model and its significance in shaping business ideas.

InnoX, the Semi-Finals of hackX Jr. 6.0, was held on the 29th of October 2023 virtually. The teams got the opportunity to pitch their groundbreaking ideas to a notable panel of judges, consisting of Ms. Miuli Kalubowila, Founder of Generation Alpha, Mr. Supun Perera, Lead Business Analyst of Azend Technologies, and Ms. Upeka Thilinimali, Co -Founder and Directress of Ample. Fifteen teams were chosen to advance to the Grand Finals based on the novelty of

their ideas, as well as considerations of feasibility and potential impact.

A workshop series was conducted for the selected finalists. Two workshops were facilitated by professionals in the field: Mr. Uditha Bandara, CEO of Bluechip Technologies Asia, covered the topic of "Minimum Viable Prototype Development", while Mr. Dimuthu Ponnamperuma, Chief Strategy Officer of Aakarsha Global (PVT) Ltd, focused on "How to Market Your Product and Growth Hacking".

The Grand Finals of hackX Jr. 6.0 was held on the 20th of November 2023, from 9.00 a.m. onwards at Dialog Axiata Auditorium, Ideamart. The honorable panel of judges were composed of Mr. Janaka Kodippili, Senior Manager, Information Technology at People's Bank, Mr. Selvarajah Selvendra, Principal Architect at Azend Technologies, Mr. Anura Adhikari, Senior Manager (Employee success) at 99x, Mr. S. Shanmugalingam, Director, Department of Information Technology at National Institute of Education, Mr. Gavashkar Subramanium, Director, Government Engagement at ICTA, Mr. Dinesh Asanka, Senior Lecturer, Department of Industrial management, Mr. Buddhika Jayawardena, Lecturer, Department of Industrial Management and Ms. Hasini Narangoda, Member of SLASSCOM Capacity Forum, Assistant Director, EY GDS Sri Lanka.

Preceded by the encouraging words from Professor Janaka Wijayanayake, Head of the Department of Industrial Management, the finalists took the stage. They presented the working prototypes of their idea in front of the distinguished panel of judges, along with the business model and future implementations. Team GeoGuardians from St. Sebastian's College, Moratuwa, which competed as a single entity, emerged as the champion after facing stiff competition. The honorable panel of judges, corporate sponsor representatives, parents, teachers, and undergraduates added colors to the event.

hackX Jr. 6.0, wouldn't be possible without the support of the partners. People's Bank as the Business Providing Partner, Azendtech as the Official Gold Partner, 99X as the Official Silver Partner, Lady J as the Official Bronze Partner, and ICTA as the National Partner along with other collaborative partners, added significant value to the event.

The chief coordinators of hackX Jr. 6.0 were Theekshana Fernando and Sadeesha Dilrangi of Level 2. Team hackX Jr. consisted of Pasindu Bhanuka, Managi Ayona, Induwara Sahasraka, and Pasindu Dilshan.

The success of the event hinged significantly on the extensive support received from the lecturers, as well as the academic and non-academic staff members, and undergraduates affiliated with the Department of Industrial Management.

INCO

INVENTION **CO**NVENTION
For Engineering Smart Systems
for Industry

In its fifth consecutive term, the Invention Convention for Engineering Smart Systems for Industry (InCo 2023) proved to be a resounding success, providing a platform for Level 2 Management and Information Technology students to showcase their innovative prowess. Organized by the Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya, InCo 2023 aimed to inspire and nurture the spirit of innovation among students while emphasizing effective marketing strategies and operations management.

The event featured a diverse array of products, each designed to address real-world challenges and contribute to smart solutions for various industries.

"CrowdSense Pro," developed by Team Alpha, who became the overall winner of the competition, is a sophisticated device designed to manage crowds effectively.

Team Innovops, the winner of the Innovation Category, presented "DriveGuard Specs", a revolutionary spectacle design aimed at preventing accidents related to drowsy driving.

"Eco Terra", which became the most popular product, by Team Incognito presented an interlocking block made from plastic waste, showcasing a commitment to sustainable practices in construction.

"Lap Secura," showcased by Team Visioneers, introduced a protective laptop back cover designed to shield laptops from physical damage and theft. Team ALLICE introduced "FIT," a versatile heating and cooling jacket that adapts to the user's needs.

Team Blacklisted brought forth "AirsensePro," a cutting-edge device capable of measuring tire pressure in real-time while vehicles are in motion. "RePELLO" by Team SparkerS is a natural portable mosquito repellent, that emphasizes sustainable and eco-friendly practices. Team Simplex showcased "ECO CUBE," a sustainable and affordable flooring solution that aligns with the growing demand for eco-friendly alternatives. The event attracted a diverse audience, including industry professionals creating an environment conducive to networking and collaboration. The presence of industry experts allowed students to receive valuable feedback and insights, further enhancing their learning experience.

In conclusion, InCo 2023 served as a testament to the creative potential of young minds in the fields of Management and Information Technology. The event underscored the importance of bridging the gap between academia and industry for a brighter, more innovative future.

KICKSTART WEEKEND 23'AT UOK

In an inspiring collaboration between the Export Development Board (EDB) and Square Hub (Pvt) Ltd, a transformative event, Kickstart Weekend 2023, was held on the 3rd, 4th, and 5th of March. Level 1 undergraduates of the Department of Industrial Management, Faculty of Science, University of Kelaniya, actively engaged in a series of workshops throughout three days at the Department of Industrial Management premises. This event aimed to empower young entrepreneurs, providing them with the essential tools for startup success through mentoring, guidance, and financial support. At the forefront of this initiative was Square Hub, an organization led by the visionary Mr. Kanishka Weeramunda, who is the founder of PayMedia (Pvt) Ltd and the Co-Founder of DirectPay (Pvt) Ltd and SquareHub (Pvt) Ltd.

A business plan competition was initiated, and students actively participated in it. Several teams were formed, and many interactive sessions were conducted to enhance the personalities and soft skills of the undergraduates. A talented mentor from the industry was assigned to each team. The title, "Best Business Idea," was clinched by Team Phantom, while the runner-up was secured by Team TalentX, and the 2nd runner-up was by Team BoardX. These victories were no easy feat, as a panel of highly experienced judges was involved in the selection process. Team Mind Boost earned the title of the most popular team after a competitive social media campaign. Team Mind Boost secured the title of media campaign. Team Mind Boost secured the title of the most popular team through a concerted collaborative endeavor aimed at cultivating widespread support and fostering engagement on various social media platforms. Also, they conducted some engaging ice-breaking activities to keep up the morale of the participants during the three-day workshop series.

Additionally, Meadowlea played a crucial role as a partner, contributing to the overall success of the initiative. The event also featured keynote addresses from distinguished personalities in the industry. Mr. Nishshanka De Silva, Mr. Sharanyan Sharma, Mr. Tharindu Dasanayake, and Mr. Kithmal Warnasooriya took the stage, sharing invaluable insights and experiences that left a lasting impact on the aspiring entrepreneurs.

Kickstart Weekend 2023 proved to be a catalyst for innovation and entrepreneurship at the University of Kelaniya. With the guidance of both Square Hub and the Export Development Board and the enthusiasm shown by the students of the Department of Industrial Management, the event not only nurtured business ideas but also laid the foundation for a future generation of successful entrepreneurs.

Life is short, the world is now more connected, and there's a lot that Sri Lanka can showcase to the rest of the world.
SANTHUSH
WEERAMAN

“If you’re an architect, don’t just focus on design.”

Santhush Weeraman is a prominent figure in the Sri Lankan music industry, renowned for his multifaceted talents as a singer, composer, and one-half of the iconic duo Bathiya and Santhush (BnS). Hailing from a musical background, Santhush’s journey began at Royal College, Colombo, where he not only excelled academically but also showcased remarkable expertise in music, art, and sports. Having completed his bachelor’s degree with a double major in Marketing and Management, he entered the corporate world before making a significant mark in the music scene. Notably, Santhush, along with Bathiya, holds the distinction of being the first Sri Lankan artist to secure a Music Publishing Contract under Universal Music Publishing and to sign a recording contract with Sony BMG, both in 2002. His accolades, including awards for outstanding contributions to the Sri Lankan music industry and collaborations with international artists, underscore his enduring impact on the cultural landscape. Beyond musical achievements, Santhush’s connection with the aspirations of the middle 80% of society has been a driving force in shaping his artistic endeavors.

Q: Are there any opening remarks or comments that you would like to share with the undergraduates?

To all undergraduates, I want to stress the importance of enjoying what you're learning in university and seeing how it connects to the real world. Don't just focus on theory; try to understand how it applies to your daily life, society, and future job. Learning with passion and practicality will make your university journey more fulfilling and relevant to your overall life experience.

Q: You started singing way back in your childhood. What would you say was the real reason behind you pursuing a career in the music industry?

I started singing when I was a kid because I love music and singing. After school, I worked at a bank, but around 3:30–4:00, I found myself losing focus, tapping on the table with a lot of music in my head. The 9:00 to 5:00 routine wasn't for me. That's when I realized my true passion was music. Music isn't just a job; it's my way of life. It holds immense value and contributes to society. It goes beyond just melodies; it's like a religion with connections to various industries. Recognizing this, I embraced music as my livelihood and lifestyle.

Q: There's no debate that BnS has caused a revolution in the music industry. Can you share insights into how your vocal training contributes to your career on a technical and musical level?

For musicians and singers, staying updated and keeping up with regular training is crucial. It's essential for anyone looking to pursue music seriously or professionally. Training and discipline play a significant role, starting from childhood experiences with jazz and opera to transitioning into pop. So, consistent training remains an important aspect of my musical journey.

Q: Having good training is not just about the technical aspects; being a good presenter and showman is crucial. What advice do you have on developing showmanship and presentation skills?

Showmanship is often overlooked in Sri Lanka, especially in schools where the focus is on theory and music without emphasizing its presentation. However, it's crucial because the audience judges you based on how you present yourself. While learning music, theory, and technical aspects, showmanship comes to life when you truly believe in what you're doing. Whether it's composing or singing a song, the key is to express yourself effectively in front of the audience. It involves understanding what you want to convey, being vocal, and presenting yourself with conviction. In music, it's like the soul of a song, where your beliefs and passion shine through. This aspect is vital for both individuals and the country to have a captivating show.

Q: The ability to persuade is not limited to the music industry. What advice do you have on presenting yourself effectively in any career?

Engaging with your thoughts is essential when presenting yourself effectively in any career. For instance, when discussing topics like climate change, it's crucial to ask yourself why you're conveying this information. Recognize the importance of sharing knowledge with future generations, as what we communicate now may not be valued by them. This applies to any subject matter, aiming to make people understand the structured world and how it can benefit them. The technical aspects are significant, but it's equally important to consider how information can be applied to people's lives and bring about positive change. This internal dialogue forms the basis for the passion needed to shed light on the issues at hand.

Q: Looking back to your childhood, is there any piece of advice you received or saw from someone that inspired you that you would like to share?

In my childhood, I encountered various instances that shaped my perspective. One memorable experience, was when I was 4 my kindergarten teacher appreciated my unique way of narrating a story. Despite the conventional approach of other students, I dared to present it differently, adding color and melody. This encouraged me to believe in myself and think differently. Another significant lesson came from my rugby days. After losing a match due to individualism, our coach instilled the importance of unity. We learned that

success comes when we play as a team, understanding our strengths and weaknesses. This taught me the value of collaboration and the strength of collective effort. embraced music as my livelihood and lifestyle.

Q: Working as a team can have both advantages and drawbacks. Can you share insights into the complexities of working as a team and how you overcome challenges with BnS?

Working in a team has its benefits, like increased output and diverse perspectives. However, it also comes with challenges due to differing ideas and preferences. To simplify, there are a few key points to consider. Firstly, mutual respect is crucial. Everyone has the right to their opinion, even if it differs. Strongly held beliefs should be communicated logically, explaining the reasoning behind them. Rationalizing arguments helps in finding solutions and prevents emotional conflicts. Understanding each other's emotions is equally important. Respecting emotions fosters harmony within the team. Additionally, having a shared goal is vital. Regular discussions about the team's purpose and how to achieve it help maintain focus. Sometimes, there may be individuals who disrupt the team dynamics due to irrationality or a lack of understanding. In such cases, it's essential to address these issues and, if necessary, make adjustments to keep the team cohesive and focused on its objectives.

Q: Is there a particular song or genre you enjoy singing more than others?

Honestly, I enjoy Broadway opera; it's a genre I'm passionate about. However, it's a bit challenging to perform that style of music in Sri Lanka as it's not widely associated with it. Overall, I appreciate a diverse range of music, from classical Carnatic to opera and even rap or Baila. The key is having a mindset that allows you to enjoy any genre.

Q: Any plans for a new genre or music album that we haven't seen before in Sri Lanka?

Possibly in the future. We have some unreleased material, and there's a chance we might explore something new.

Q: Beyond your musical career, you're involved in managing companies. What advice do you have for undergraduates from a businessman's perspective?

What I'd suggest to undergraduates is to diversify their knowledge. While specializing in your field, don't limit yourself to just that. For instance, if you're studying music, it's beneficial to grasp some basics of economics, finance, and marketing, both locally and globally. Narrowing your focus solely on your major might not be enough. Read books, explore different disciplines, and engage with various subjects. If you're an architect, don't just focus on design. Learn a bit about accounting and understand the processes involved in estimating project costs. You don't need to be an expert, but understanding different perspectives will make you a more versatile professional. This broader understanding helps you work effectively with people from different backgrounds and ensures you're not confined to a single way of thinking. Remember, whatever you do in your career is ultimately for people, so having diverse knowledge will equip you to contribute meaningfully in various aspects, not just in your specific field.

Q: The importance of 'Personal Branding' is evident in your case. What advice do you have for undergraduates on personal branding?

Building a personal brand starts with understanding your product or what you represent. Take our music, for example. Bathiya and I create songs with a purpose—we aim to share the sound of Sri Lankan music with the world, add value to the industry, and instill confidence in youth. We want to be part of various meaningful spaces. These reasons breathe life into our product, and from there, the brand naturally evolves. So, without a genuine passion for your field and clarity on your goals and reasons, personal branding shouldn't be your focus.

Q: Any closing remarks for the undergraduates?

Thank you so much for our wonderful conversation. I'd like to extend my best wishes to all the undergraduates. Life is short, the world is now more connected, and there's a lot that Sri Lanka can showcase to the rest of the world. Opportunities are waiting for you. All the very best!

Four outlooks

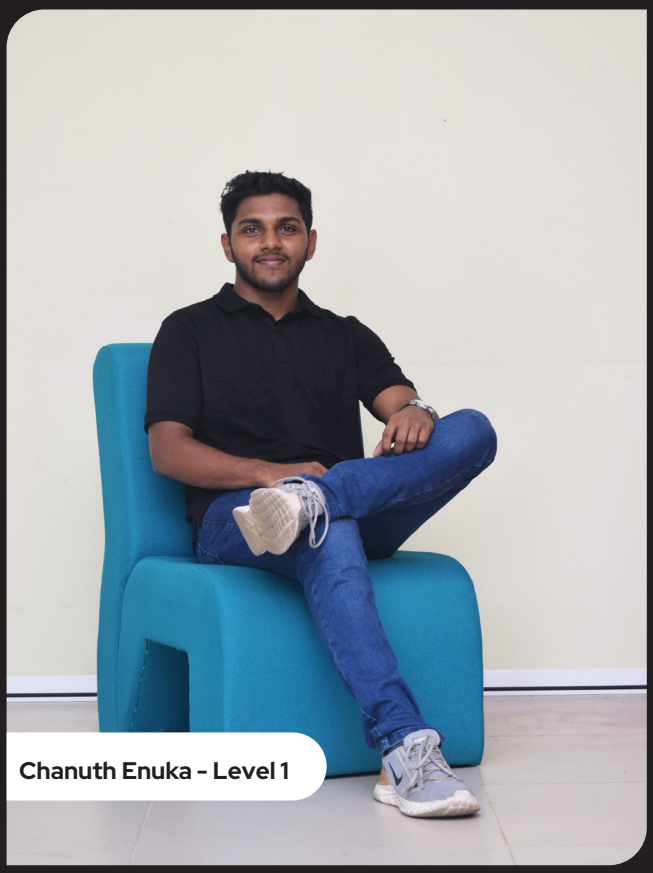
One expedition

Setting forth on separate paths, each with distinct dreams and ambitions, yet bound together in unity as the IM family.

The Freshman

LEVEL 1

Evolving Chronicles



Chanuth Enuka - Level 1

Q: As a level 1 undergraduate in the Department of Industrial Management, what were your first impressions of the degree program, and how have your initial expectations aligned with the experience so far?

As a Level 1 undergraduate, my first impression of this degree was a mix of excitement and uncertainty. I was thrilled to be a part of this IM department as I have the chance to gain knowledge from both IT and Management fields. After joining the department, it was proved to me that my decision to join this degree program was the best decision that I have ever made. Interactions with professors and my fellow batchmates further enriched my learning experience, providing valuable insights and diverse perspectives. I grabbed the opportunity to engage in both academic and extracurricular activities at the same time at the university, and that's the uni-life I always wanted. So, I am grateful to be a part of this IM family.

365 x 1

One year
4 levels
4 stories

Q: Transitioning from high school to university can be challenging. How have you navigated this transition, both academically and personally?

It was challenging to adapt to the new environment in the university as a freshman, but the DIM supported me at their best to transform into this environment. The department holds various activities including ice-breaking sessions to improve the bond within the batch. My fellow batchmates helped me with maintaining my peace of mind and relieving stress. The university environment fostered critical thinking and independent problem-solving, helping me to develop a deeper understanding of life. As I have adapted to this environment now, I hope to gain much more experience and make my life successful.

Q: Are you currently engaged in any extracurricular activities? If so, could you share what you are involved in, and how you balance these activities with your coursework?

Yes, I'm actively involved in playing rugby as an extracurricular activity alongside my academic activities. Balancing rugby and coursework has been a challenging yet rewarding experience for me. Time management is crucial, and therefore I have planned my study sessions according to a timetable. I prioritize assignments and exams to ensure I meet academic requirements. I often find that engaging in physical activity, such as rugby, helps me stay focused and energized when tackling academic tasks. Overall, finding the right balance between rugby and coursework has been a learning process, but it has enriched my university experience and contributed to my personal and academic growth.

Q: Have you had opportunities to network with professionals in your field of study? How does the department facilitate industry collaborations?

Yeah, I got multiple opportunities to network with various professionals within both IT and Management fields. DIM organized several sessions and field visits to make us more exposed to the industrial world. These experiences not only enhance our practical skills but also provide networking opportunities that can be beneficial for future career endeavors. These initiatives bridge the gap between academia and industry, ensuring that we are well-prepared and connected as we enter the workforce. As an MITian, I feel very lucky enough to experience these opportunities through the Department of Industrial Management.

The Sophomore

LEVEL 2

Navigating the Journey

Q: As a passionate second-year undergraduate, could you share how the Department of Industrial Management has influenced your university experience and contributions?

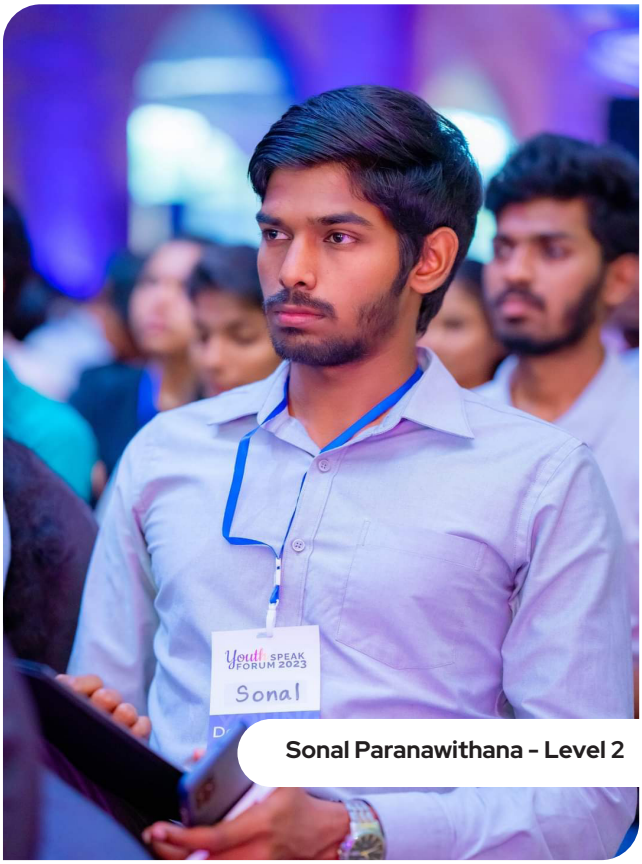
Initially, when I was selected for the degree program, I was not familiar with the environment and what this institution had to offer its students. However, after spending a couple of years at the university, I understood that the Department of Industrial Management is a wonderful place with a diverse set of opportunities to thrive in both our personal and professional lives. Just to give an example, we were provided with the opportunity to participate in Outbound Training Programs (OBT), organizing major events including hackX, hackX Jr., and Exposition, and other openings to collaborate with the lecturers on overseas projects.

Q: What prompted your focus on the management and information technology pathway? How do you envision this specialization enhancing your future career prospects?

Well, I believe my initial reaction when I got selected for the degree was quite positive, due to the combination of subjects that complement each other, and it is pretty useful in the corporate field. I believe the job opportunities available in this field of interest are quite exciting considering the abundance of opportunities and the pay associated with it. In our degree program, Business Systems Engineering & Operations and Supply Chain Management are the couple of specializations in which I am interested. This is due to my interest in understanding core business functions and the desire to network.

Q: Winning multiple hackathon competitions is an impressive achievement. Can you provide more details about the achievements you have experienced in university life, particularly in the context of hackathon competitions?

Well, I certainly wish that we would be able to achieve much more than the accomplishments we have as of now. But if I were to give a brief overview of how it is now, the journey has been nothing but invigorating. A strong team combination, including my other level 2 batchmates Chamil, Pathum, and other dedicated teammates who possess various skills in different fields of interest, made a lot of victories become a reality. For instance, we were Champions of the SLT Mobitel Code Blast Hackathon,



Sonal Paranawithana - Level 2

1st Runner-up of the 'Lazarus' Ideathon organized by the IEEE PES Student Branch Chapter of SLIIT, and numerous other hackathons that we participated in. The exposure and connections I received through these events were certainly immaculate.

Q: How do you believe your prior school experiences have shaped your role as a radio and TV presenter at Sri Lanka Broadcasting Corporation and Rupavahini Corporation, influencing your presenting approach and perspective?

As a school student at Thurstan College, I engaged in multiple activities, including Cricket, Debating, Quiz Club, English Literary Circle, Dramas, and the Media Club. This wide variety of pursuits paved the way for me to build my foundations as a presenter in front of an audience. I used to have performance anxiety (and still have it to some extent), but with time I overcame it and became an impromptu speaker. Now I can speak in front of a massive crowd without any hesitation. Involving in a plethora of extra-curriculars excluding essential academic activities can make you an all-rounder, in my case, a radio and TV presenter, whilst being a full-time undergraduate.

Q: As a radio and TV presenter, what skills do you think you have developed that are transferable to your academic and professional life?

A two-word answer to this question: Presentation skills. You get ample amounts of opportunities to present in front of a panel of lecturers (Vivas), a panel of judges (Competitions), and your batchmates. Most of the time, the complex information on a specific subject is simplified in my presentations.

My experience as a media personality helped me achieve freelance gigs such as corporate events, panel discussions, research conferences, wedding emceeing and much more. I was one of the main comperes of the International Research Conference on Smart Computing and Systems Engineering (SCSE 2023), which was hosted by the Department of Industrial Management itself.

Q: Your role as a Unilever Sparks Student Ambassador and as an organizer for the Unilever Youth Forum 2024 should certainly be a unique experience. What is that exposure like?

The Sparks Student Ambassadorship is a great way to meet new enthusiastic individuals from across the island who will be working together for a period of one year. We get to meet and gain advice from top officials at Unilever Sri Lanka, visit factories, coordinate university events, and organize the Unilever Youth Forum. Also, the ability to understand how important the input of each individual is to succeed in a specific goal is iterated. This ambassadorship has made me a point of contact for my university undergraduates to know the potential job openings at Unilever, which allows me to connect with a wide variety of students and network.

Q: In juggling your roles as a radio and TV presenter, a freelance compere, and a student ambassador, how do you efficiently manage your time to maintain a balance among academic responsibilities, extracurricular activities, and your career pursuits?

That is an important question. To be honest, I have not precisely found the secret to maintaining everything at a given period. But I can confidently believe I am on the right path to do that. I am a person who believes that doing only one thing at a time without utilizing all available time is a waste. I believe that one should keep oneself occupied with different fields of interest at a given moment so that when you look back, you have a significant number of achievements to look back on. My self-motivation factor comes from within; I always remind myself to strive for more.

Q: Your diverse skill set suggests you excel in multitasking. Can you elaborate on how you contribute to the Department of Industrial Management with your varied capabilities?

I believe I have great interpersonal skills, which come in handy in various situations. Specifically, when finding partnerships for events such as hackX and hackX Jr., I reached out to corporate partners, where I explained how we could come to a win-win situation if a partnership surfaced. Also, a radio interview was arranged to promote hackX in collaboration with Radio Sri Lanka of the Sri Lanka Broadcasting Corporation, where the department head, Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake, and myself took part in the interview. Additionally, as a Sparks Student Ambassador, I organize sessions where interested undergraduate students are updated on the latest job opportunities, career tips, and advice from the global FMCG company Unilever. In these ways, I manage to contribute to the department to the best of my ability.

Q: Very recently you got a priceless opportunity as a professional compere, to take part in the 'Independence Day Celebrations.' Could you briefly share that unique experience with us?

To be frank, in any professional compere's life, announcing at the National Independence Day Celebrations is a dream come true. At a young age, I managed to earn that opportunity through my active participation at the Sri Lanka Broadcasting Corporation, which is considered quite a rare occurrence. At the 76th Independence Day Celebrations held at the Galle Face Green, I announced in front of hundreds of delegates representing different entities in Sri Lanka, including His Excellency the President of Sri Lanka.

365 x 2 | One year, 4 levels, 4 stories

The Intern

Harvesting Expertise

Q: Can you tell us a bit about yourself and your journey to the Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya?

I am a bit of a dabbler, with interests scattered across various fields. Throughout my life, I have always been captivated by the idea of innovation and progress. From an early age, I was part of a young inventors' club, which sparked my interest in science and technology. This fascination was what led me to do my advanced-level exams in the biological science stream. I was weighing the number of higher education options before me when I received the UGC acceptance letter to pursue a degree at the Department of Industrial Management.

In my first year, I realized that my passion was more towards the managerial side of software projects. So, I opted to pursue a degree in Management and IT, specializing in Information Systems.

Now, in the final stretch of my internship as an IT business analyst at ADL, the dynamic nature of the work aligns seamlessly with my love for versatility and integrating management with IT. So far, this journey has equipped me with a unique set of skills and experiences, and I am eager to see where it leads me next.

Harini Jayasundara - Level 3

365 x 3

One year
4 levels
4 stories

Q: As an intern at ADL, what valuable insights or skills have you gained that you believe are transferable to your academic and professional growth?

I am currently interning in the practice of Telco Solutions. My primary responsibilities involve requirement identification, analysis, and documentation. This entails delving into client needs, exploring various solutions, and meticulously analyzing their pros and cons before presenting the most viable option. The experience has not only refined my communication skills and analytical abilities but also deepened my understanding of how to approach and solve complex issues. Additionally, being part of a professional setting has given me a firsthand look into workplace dynamics and effective communication with diverse teams.

This exposure has been instrumental in developing my people skills and understanding the intricacies of collaborative work.

Moreover, the exposure to growing trends in customer expectations has been invaluable. Understanding what customers look for and industry trends has not only equipped me for the current professional landscape but also served as an eye-opener for potential areas of research.

Q: How did your academic knowledge of Industrial Management translate into practical application during your internship?

As I mentioned, my primary responsibilities revolve around requirement elicitation, analysis, and creating documentation such as FRS and user manuals. The theoretical foundations in modules such as Information Systems Modeling and Requirements Engineering directly influenced my approach to these tasks. For instance, the experience of drawing UML diagrams proved instrumental in crafting process workflows. Furthermore, the programming-related modules and the individual software development project gave me a more in-depth technical understanding. This knowledge proved valuable

during grooming sessions, where I had to effectively communicate client requirements and propose solutions to the development team.

Additionally, the experience gained through assignments like presentations and active involvement in department events helped me to coordinate knowledge-sharing sessions and organize a meetup for the Business Consulting CEG at ADL. The skills honed during these academic activities made it easier for me to plan, communicate, and execute the events, ensuring a seamless and engaging experience for all participants.

Q: Involvement in departmental events is commendable. Could you discuss a specific event or project that you found particularly rewarding or challenging?

I have primarily contributed as a content writer for most of the events organized by the department. However, a standout experience would be my role as the session coordinator for hackX Jr. 5.0.

I was taking charge of coordinating sessions that involved contacting industry experts, organizing workshops, and managing the flow of knowledge-sharing sessions. This responsibility became particularly challenging as the sessions were conducted virtually. Ensuring the sessions ran smoothly required meticulous planning, effective task delegation, and having backup plans in case.

Reflecting on the experience, it was the small victories, such as securing a speaker, ensuring smooth session execution, and receiving acknowledgment for a job well done, that were the most rewarding. These instances, combined with the event's overall success, have significantly enriched my understanding of event coordination, fostering adaptability, and teamwork, qualities that I believe are crucial, especially in a professional setting.

Q: You mentioned being involved in various department events. Can you share some memorable experiences and skills gained through these participations?

For all the departmental events I have been involved in, the most memorable aspect was the collective effort of our batch on the day of each event. It was heartening to see how our batch came together during the final events to ensure everything unfolded smoothly. Although the coordinators took the lead, everyone took ownership to ensure the events were a success.

In terms of skills gained, the foremost would be enhanced communication skills. My roles in hackX Jr. and the grand finals of hackX provided me with opportunities to interact with industry professionals. These experiences not only bolstered my ability to communicate effectively but also played a pivotal role in navigating internship interviews with confidence.

Additionally, my experience writing articles for Exposition's previous issue proved valuable during my internship, as I contributed to the Business Consulting CEG's quarterly newsletter by writing articles and conducting interviews.

Q: With a strong academic GPA, what study habits or strategies have you found most effective for your academic success?

Based on my experience, first and foremost would be consistent attendance at lectures. I have noticed that I have performed better on the modules for which I have attended every lecture, as doing so facilitates a comprehensive understanding of the study material. I also find re-writing important points helpful. Even if the lecturer has provided all the lecture material in a short, concise manner, rewriting it in my own words and reading it back helps me retain it.

I also believe that 'to teach is to learn twice over.' I have witnessed the reciprocal benefits of reinforcing my understanding through assisting my peers during 'kuppi' sessions.

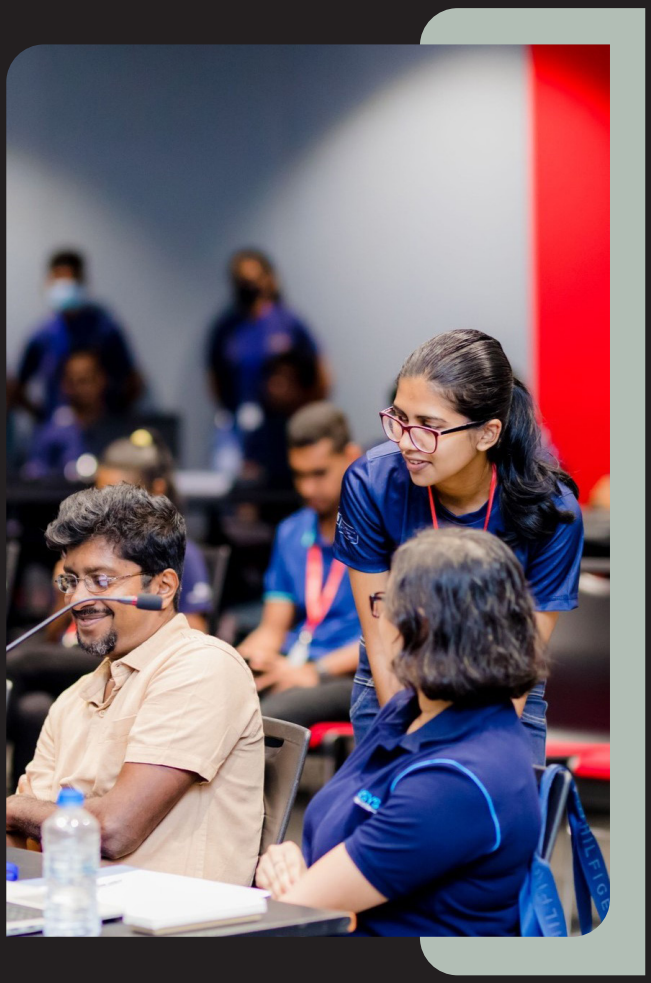
Lastly, a practice that has proven highly effective for me is completing at least one past paper before each exam. This serves as a practice exam but also aids in understanding the nature of questions and the mark breakdown. It allows me to strategize and plan my exam approach more effectively.

Q: What advice would you offer to someone aspiring to excel in Industrial Management, both academically and professionally?

Firstly, make continuous learning a part of your journey. Stay curious and updated on the latest industry trends and technological advancements. Attend seminars and workshops and delve into modern technologies so that you are always one step ahead on technical advancements. Engage in real-world projects and internships during your academic years. It is the hands-on experience that truly solidifies your understanding and prepares you for the challenges you will face in your professional career.

Soft skills are the unsung heroes in this field. So, get involved in group projects, collaborate with diverse teams, and embrace situations that demand adaptability, as these skills will make you stand out from the crowd. Also, networking is a game-changer. Connect with industry professionals, attend networking events, and seek out mentors who can provide guidance based on their experiences. These connections can open doors to invaluable insights and potential career opportunities.

Remember, the world of Industrial Management is dynamic. Embrace change, be resilient, and see challenges as opportunities for growth, and success will come your way.



"WE DONT REALISE WE ARE MAKING MEMORIES, WE JUST KNOW WE ARE HAVING FUN"

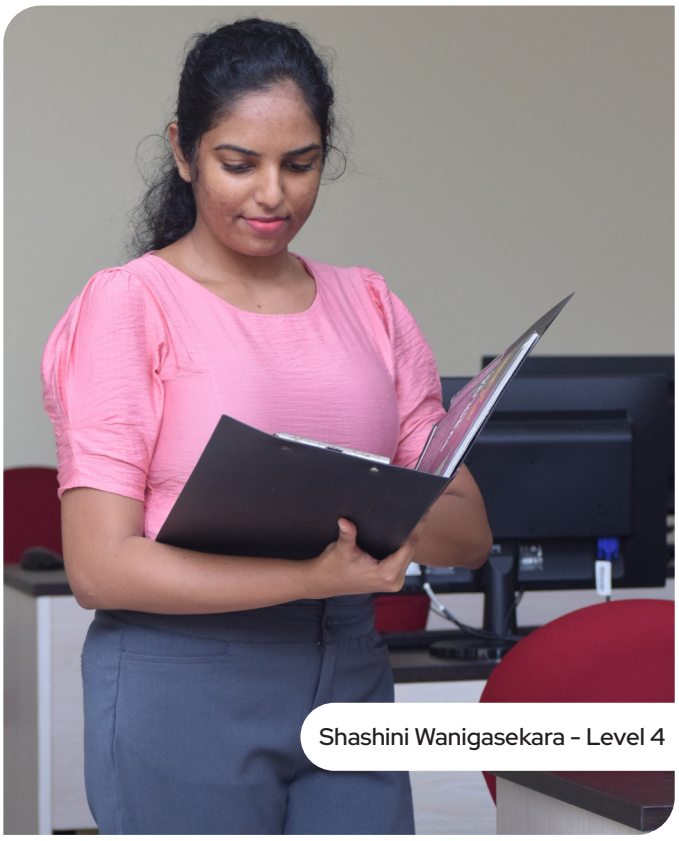
The Senior

Pinnacle of Experience

Q: As an enthusiastic undergraduate, how do you explain the contribution that you have been given by the Department of Industrial Management in all aspects so far? How do you explain your university life there?

As an MIT undergraduate, I am deeply grateful for the opportunities and experiences that the Department of Industrial Management (DIM) has provided me over the past four years. From the very beginning, the Department of Industrial Management emphasized to me the importance of a balanced university life, encouraging us to participate in extracurricular activities such as sports, university clubs, and voluntary projects along with academics. It allowed me to develop both my professional and personal skills. Even during the first two years, when most of our activities were conducted online due to the COVID-19 pandemic, we managed to create memorable experiences.

Beyond academics, we were involved in numerous events that provided us with corporate exposure. These events, coupled with webinars and workshops, equipped us with valuable knowledge and hands-on experience. They also fostered a sense of unity among us, making every challenge a collective success.



Shashini Wanigasekara - Level 4

> **STEP OUTSIDE YOUR COMFORT ZONE, TAKE CALCULATED RISKS, AND BUILD THE SKILL SET THAT MAKES YOU STAND OUT FROM THE CROWD.**

The industry mentorship program was another invaluable opportunity, as we had the privilege of being guided by industry professionals who shared their insights and experiences with us. For me, it played a crucial role in shaping my future career.

One of the highlights of my university life was participating in hackathons, ideathons, and designathons. These competitions not only honed my problem-solving abilities but also boosted my confidence. Winning these competitions was a tribute to the hard work and dedication of my teammates and myself.

Not only that, but the department's recognition of the importance of nurturing our talents in various fields such as arts, music, and drama provided a platform where we could express ourselves freely and explore our creative sides. At last, reflecting on my university life at the Department of Industrial Management, it's a pleasure to mention that it has been a journey of continuous learning, growth, and success. I am proud to be part of this vibrant community and look forward to carrying these invaluable experiences into my future endeavours.

365 x 4 | One year, 4 levels, 4 stories

Q: Why did you choose Information Technology as your specialized pathway, and what sparked your passion for this field?

To be honest, I entered the MIT degree program with my sights set on the Information Technology specialization. In the first 2 years, as we gained fundamental knowledge and hands-on experience through projects, I became increasingly convinced that IT would be the path that would lead me to reach my future career goal. Apart from academics, the sessions, webinars, and competitions I participated in led me to take this decision.

Q: How did the knowledge you gained from the MIT degree program help you complete your internship as a Quality Assurance Engineer successfully?

One of the key advantages was the opportunity to get mentored by an industry professional prior to the industrial training (internship) at level 2. This mentorship provided me with a glimpse into the corporate world and helped me understand the skill set and qualifications needed to perform well in the industry. The course content of the degree program supported my personal growth. It helped me improve my personality traits, interpersonal skills, attitudes, and problem-solving skills, all of which are crucial for success in a career.

Q: Why did you decide to go to level 4 despite the opportunity to end your degree at level 3 as a general degree?

Upon returning to the DIM from my internship, I was strongly inspired to engage in research and gain hands-on experience. My career path had shifted towards Software Quality Assurance, and I saw this as an excellent opportunity to undertake a critical research project that directly relates to my area of interest.

Additionally, the supportive and collaborative nature of the DIM and supervisors played a significant role in my decision. Their guidance and insights were invaluable in shaping my research direction and ensuring its success.

Therefore, despite the opportunity to conclude my degree at Level 3, I chose to proceed to Level 4. I believed that this additional level of study would allow me to gain a deeper understanding of the subject matter, acquire advanced skills, and prepare myself better for the challenges of the industry.

Q: How has your time in the Department of Industrial Management contributed to the success of your research project?

At the beginning of the research project, I lacked specific knowledge on how to approach or progress with the research project. However, the department provided me with the opportunity to learn while conducting the research and guided me throughout the process. My research aimed to address a specific problem within the industry, and my research project supervisor and co-supervisors were highly supportive and collaborative throughout the project. They provided some important suggestions and valuable insights to make the research a success. Moreover, the department held special sessions for us during our research period, which provided us with the necessary knowledge and supported us in the data analysis in order to achieve our desired results and findings.

Q: Are you satisfied with the knowledge (both theoretical and practical) you have gained so far from this degree program to survive in today's competitive industry?

From day one, we weren't just taught; we were built. The program has been structured precisely, providing us with a timely skill set and abilities that align perfectly with the demands of today's competitive industry. My exposure to real-world scenarios through internships has further solidified my understanding of the practical applications of the theories learned in university. This combination of theoretical knowledge and practical exposure has equipped me with a unique set of skills that enable me to stand out in the industry. Moreover, the leadership qualities exhibited by the seniors have inspired me to take initiatives, embrace challenges, and venture into new territories. This mindset has been instrumental in my ability to seize opportunities and open doors that I once dreamed of.

Observing the industry, I notice that MITians are consistently recognized for their performance and the attitude they bring to their roles. This recognition is a testament to the quality of education provided by DIM and the valuable experiences it offers. These four years at DIM have shaped me into the individual I am today. I'm proud and eternally grateful for the knowledge, commitment, and transformative experiences provided by the DIM.

Q: As a proud senior undergraduate, what guidance or recommendations would you provide to junior undergraduates within the Department of Industrial Management?

The clock isn't ticking; it's sprinting. Remember that you once dreamed of being an undergraduate? Now, here we are, but before you know it, these four years will fly by, and you'll be in your final days at the university.

Seek out opportunities, be they research projects, internships, industry workshops, or international exposure programs. Step outside your comfort zone, take calculated risks, and build the skillset that makes you stand out from the crowd. Don't settle for being a passive passenger on this journey by just surviving these years; thrive in them.

Use these years to identify your weaknesses and turn them into strengths. Hone your communication and leadership skills through clubs and activities. Embrace every chance to sharpen your technical and soft skills; they'll be your weapons in the professional arena.

Your peers aren't just classmates; they're your future colleagues, collaborators, and even competitors. Participate in conferences, attend alumni events, and leverage social media platforms to cultivate a strong network. Remember, your network is your net worth.

One phase reminds me to mention here, which I heard on the first day at the Department of Industrial Management, and it is indeed true: "Nothing is impossible for MIT undergraduates." It's not just a motto; it's a mindset. Our department fosters a spirit of unwavering belief and relentless innovation. Embrace the "can-do" attitude, learn from your failures, and never let self-doubt dim your potential. Remember, anything is possible when you set your mind to it.

Amidst the academic rigor, don't forget to enjoy the journey. Cherish the friendships you forge, the late-night study sessions, and the triumphs, big and small. As you graduate, let it be with a graceful heart, brimming with memories, and ready to conquer the world.

Q: As an active member of university clubs, what benefits have you gained from those extracurricular activities for your professional career?

After the orientation period, with the COVID-19 pandemic, university premises were inaccessible for nearly a year and a half, and we weren't able to do sports and other extracurricular activities physically. However, the virtual realm offered a surprising alternative: it was possible for us to join university clubs online. I actively participated in project initiatives organized by these clubs, finding myself collaborating with undergraduates from other faculties and departments of the university. Choosing to participate in club projects proved to be a transformative experience. During working on these projects, I was able to develop my interpersonal skills, soft skills and improve the ability to work with individuals from different places, cultures, ethnic groups and attitudes. This invaluable experience laid the foundation for a strong network that continues to benefit me in my professional life, facilitating seamless communication and collaboration even within the dynamic world of industry.

This exposure not only enriched my university life but also equipped me with essential skills for navigating the professional world with confidence and grace. The foundation built through my university club experiences continues to be a cornerstone of my professional journey.

> "Nothing is impossible for MITians

Industrial Week '24

The Industrial Management Science Students' Association (IMSSA) has marked a significant milestone in its history with the successful inception of the Exposition - Industrial Week 2024, parallel to Exposition Magazine Issue 19. The Exposition - Industrial Week was a three-day career fair, exclusively designed for undergraduates and fresh graduates of the University of Kelaniya to unlock pathways to their dream careers. The attendees got the opportunity to connect with the top industry professionals, explore internships, training programs, and permanent recruitment opportunities offered by the leading companies in Sri Lanka. The career guidance workshops held alongside the career fair, provided participants with guidance on proper CV making, personal branding on LinkedIn, and steps to achieve their dream careers.

Hosted from the 19th to the 21st of February 2024 at the Department of Industrial Management, Faculty of Science, University of Kelaniya, the event featured the participation of 15 leading companies and attracted approximately 300+ attendees from different faculties at the University of Kelaniya. Prior to the career fair, participants submitted their CVs, which were then shortlisted. Additionally, walk-in interviews were conducted on all three days.

On the opening day, the well-known companies, Evonsys and Stretchline partnered, offering valuable opportunities for internships and permanent roles in the areas of IT, Computer Science, Marketing, Supply Chain Management, Logistics, Electronics, Chemistry, and Physical Science. The following day, one of the leading companies, LSEG partnered for a full day, providing opportunities mainly for the Finance and Management areas. Notably, Stretchline and LSEG joined as Talent Partners for the Exposition Industrial Week 2024. Wrapping up on the 21st of February, a full career day with the participation of all leading companies, namely EvonSys, XigeniX, GTN, Fortude, Ernest & Young, 99x, hSenid Lanka, Logicare, Wiley, Cambio, Connex IT, Hemas, and Advantis was held successfully, providing valuable internships and permanent job opportunities for the participants. They got valuable opportunities to find careers in the areas of IT, Computer Science, Data Science, Electronics, Chemistry, Physical Science, Statistics, Supply Chain Management, Logistics, ERP, Marketing, Finance, Accounting and Management.

The Exposition - Industrial Week 2024 was able to create a meaningful and mutually beneficial experience for all involved, fostering connections and opening doors to exciting opportunities within the realm of Management and IT.

Industrial Week '24 Partners

TALENT PARTNERS

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Financially Fit or Personally Fit?

By Dinithi Lorensuhewa | University of Kelaniya

Have you ever wondered what matters to make you financially fit? Answers might include an excellent job that pays you well, a good education and qualifications, and maybe a good family background, which I think is the least important if you have the former criterion. Yet does being financially fit mean that you are psychologically fit? In other words, does having money or an excellent job that pays you well make you a self-satisfied, self-confident, and happy soul?

Entrepreneurship, which is a trend-setting profession, provides a dynamic and enduring aspect of the job market. It is noteworthy that the self-satisfaction an ordinary nine-to-five job provides you with can be multiplied when you are a part of this risky yet worth-the-try profession, "Entrepreneur." While there may be fluctuations in the popularity of entrepreneurial pursuits, the fundamental drive to create and innovate has been a constant in various economies throughout history.

> **TRUE ENJOYMENT COMES FROM ACTIVITY OF THE MIND AND EXERCISE OF THE BODY; THE TWO ARE EVER UNITED.**

If you come across this urge to do something new, to do something out of the box, something extraordinarily exceptional, to step out of the mundane 'chakra' life, it is that signal you have been waiting for; your entrepreneurial instincts have awakened. The very decision you plan to take, to change the whole perspective of earning through an ordinary job, is what makes you different from the entire world of professionals who run in a cat race, trying to go beyond and above their capabilities, risking and testing their skills, and feeling confident and satisfied enough to wake up the next day and go ahead with the usual chores.

Taking risks-risking your claims, risking your time, and risking your capacities, to hold on tight and immerse yourself in the professional world you desire to be a part of is never a route not to be taken. It is exactly where you should be heading right now! At the end of the day, you reap the fruits of your hard work, so why not reap fruits from your garden of fruits? Thus, as an entrepreneur, you will be financially fit by doing something you love, which gives you a bonus each passing day, a bundle full of self-satisfaction, self-confidence, and happiness!

There is no easy way to do anything in life. Deciding the path you should be moving forward is also the same. But once you choose the entrepreneurial path, you have ownership and responsibility for what you started. This ownership and responsibility together make you engulf yourself in a never-ending entrepreneurship discipline that you will have to abide by infinitely. While being an entrepreneur gives you emancipation to do what you love the way you want, it does not make you emancipated enough not to anticipate inconveniences. Thus, be it in financial or management procedures, such issues can be limited if you abide by the disciplinary rules.

Delving deeper into the realm of entrepreneurship, it becomes evident that the path is characterized by a continuous process of learning and adaptation. No new expedition has an easy way in or an easy way out. It requires 100% hard work and 100% perseverance.

Entrepreneurs often find themselves at the forefront of industry changes, requiring a prudent mindset to stay ahead. This perpetual learning curve fosters intellectual growth and cultivates an entrepreneurial spirit that thrives on curiosity and the pursuit of knowledge.

In the entrepreneurial landscape, effective communication is a linchpin for success. Entrepreneurs must articulate their vision persuasively to stakeholders, investors, and team members. Mastering the art of communication is a discipline, as it involves not only conveying ideas clearly but also fostering a collaborative environment where diverse perspectives can flourish. The ability to inspire and lead through effective communication distinguishes successful entrepreneurs in their endeavors.

An integral facet of entrepreneurial discipline is the ability to embrace failure as a stepping stone to success. Unlike the conventional corporate structure, where failure might be stigmatized, entrepreneurship encourages a mindset shift. Failure in the entrepreneurial world is not a reason to be demotivated or a reason to step back, saying, "It is too risky; I should stop!" Instead, it will always become a journey, giving ample reasons to stop, but those reasons should be viewed as invaluable lessons that propel individuals toward refinement and improvement. This resilience in the face of adversity is a testament to the mental fortitude developed through entrepreneurship. Being an entrepreneur, you will be engulfed with an obscure strength or enigmatic voice that will always whisper "Never give up; your journey has yet to begin!"

Furthermore, the entrepreneurial journey is intrinsically tied to the concept of innovation. Successful entrepreneurs are often those who challenge existing norms, identify gaps in the market, and pioneer novel solutions. This commitment to innovation necessitates a mindset that thrives on creativity and adaptability. The discipline of entrepreneurship, therefore, extends beyond the logistical and financial realms to encompass a culture of perpetual innovation. Being an entrepreneur does not make you less than any other professional in the field; remember, you will always be looked at as a challenge, which makes your responsibility to do something original much more complicated and huge. As an entrepreneur, you should not delve into the complexities that come across yet comprehend and move along the tide.

As entrepreneurs navigate the intricacies of their ventures, time management becomes a critical aspect of maintaining discipline. With numerous responsibilities and a dynamic work environment, entrepreneurs must prioritize tasks effectively. The discipline of time management not only enhances productivity but also contributes to a balanced and sustainable entrepreneurial lifestyle. This ability to juggle multiple priorities is a hallmark of seasoned entrepreneurs who understand the significance of time as a valuable resource.

If you hit the right bird at the right time, you will be crowned with so much appreciation and a sense of fulfillment that you have never felt throughout your life. Being an entrepreneur is not a convenient option; nonetheless, nothing can be fulfilled in a bed of roses; every achievement requires hard work, perseverance, commitment, and strong willpower.

The discipline of entrepreneurship encompasses a multifaceted approach that goes beyond financial considerations. Therefore, your entrepreneurial expedition is a journey that not only makes you financially equipped but also allows for personal growth. It is indeed a full package of financial and psychological satisfaction!

Ms. Dinithi Lorensuhewa
University of Kelaniya.

Edify 2023

INTER - UNIVERSITY ARTICLE COMPETITION

Continuing its dedication to kindling the intellectual spark and enhancing the value of creativity among university students, Exposition embarks on the third iteration of the inter-university article competition in collaboration with the long-running intra-departmental article competition. The vibrant engagement of participants, driven to share their creative insights in Exposition magazine, serves as an implicit testament to the success of the inspiring endeavor.

2nd Place

Ashmini Karunarathna
University of Colombo

1st Place

Dinithi Lorensuhewa
University of Kelaniya

3rd Place

Sudeepa Lakshan
University of Peradeniya

https://blog.exposition.lk/

INTRA - DEPARTMENTAL ARTICLE COMPETITION

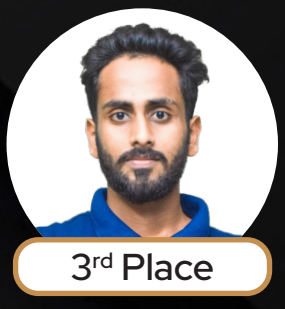
The intra-departmental article competition allows our department undergraduates to exhibit their prowess in creative writing and innovative thinking. All department undergraduates are urged to craft articles about information technology, management, and entrepreneurship, with winning entries gaining exposure in Exposition magazine. Beyond being an avenue for students to articulate their thoughts, this competition is also a means of sharing knowledge and creating a sense of community.

2nd Place

Sanjitha Nimsara
Level 1

1st Place

Kushani Apsara
Level 1



3rd Place

Pasindu Bhanuka
Level 2

Knowledge without practice is useless, while practice without knowledge is dangerous.
KANCHANA
PRIYAKANTHA

> “If you are afraid or scared of seizing the opportunities and experiences in your life, you will never be able to see the beauty and magic within it.”

Kanchana Priyakantha is a distinguished figure in Sri Lanka’s literary and entrepreneurial landscapes. As the founder and CEO of KBOOKS, a leading online book retailer, and KReader.lk, a digital reading platform, she has significantly advanced literature’s accessibility and promotion in the country. In 2017, Kanchana co-founded KBOOKS, followed by the establishment of KReader in 2022, where she currently serves as the co-founder and CEO of both ventures while continuing to pursue her writing endeavors. Since her school days, Kanchana has exhibited a profound interest in literature, which led her to author twelve books in various genres in both Sinhala and English, including the acclaimed “Dream Catchers,” which earned national recognition in 2019. Her literary contributions extend beyond borders, with translations of her works available in English, Tamil, and Nepali. Beyond her literary pursuits, Kanchana is the coordinator for the Foundation of SAARC Writers and Literature in India, representing Sri Lanka internationally. Her educational publications are integrated into various school curricula, highlighting her influence in education.

Kanchana’s tidings include the SAARC and FOSWAL Literary Awards in 2023, along with securing second place in the “She Loves Tech” local rounds in the same year, showcasing her entrepreneurial acumen and commitment to technological innovation in literature.

Q: Kanchana, as you go through your diverse fields of interest, you are not only one person; you have different areas like an educator, an entrepreneur, and most importantly, a literary advocate. How would you describe yourself? Who is Kanchana?

If you want me to answer that question, the answer is very simple. Kanchana Priyakantha is a human who exists on Earth. She has played different roles at various times in her life and continues to play different roles. Whatever role I assume, I'd like to do my best to make that role shine. I believe that every role one plays in their life is equally important and matters. No role is more important than another. The purpose of every role is to contribute to the betterment of the world.

Q: You being you, you being in this position, if we look back, there has to be some way that your childhood has been achieved, having this personality and talented set of skills. If we look at your childhood, what kind of experiences motivated you to be the person you are today?

We were a middle-class family. I must say that what shaped my personality was mostly freedom. I was given immense freedom during my early and middle childhood. I climbed trees and played with kids around, yet I was well looked after, well fed, and well dressed. I received a good education. "I was not a child who had been spoon-fed".

Sometimes, my parents just left me alone to solve my problems and find my way. When I decided to write for the children's corners in newspapers, they helped me by publishing them. My parents continuously encouraged me. They never forget to appreciate my achievements. I was a clever student and managed to get good marks. Every time I managed to get good marks, they appreciated me. Very rarely did I get marks below eighty, yet I was never blamed for not getting 100. My achievements were appreciated. Many teachers and friends liked me. Even during my adolescence, I had adults around me who trusted me. They trusted my decisions, and many people relied on my actions and decisions. I was not forced. It was like people always had faith in me. They supported my decisions. You know, that's what creates confidence in you.

I attended two schools. During our school days, we were never spoon-fed. We were given the freedom to decide for ourselves. We were not told which cover to put on our books or this and that. Most importantly, we were allowed to play and engage in extra-curricular and co-curricular activities. Most of the time, I decided where I should be and where I should go. Even when my decisions sometimes didn't work as expected, I was not criticized. What shapes your personality is the environment you are raised in, what you are exposed to, and how you are exposed—most importantly, how you are treated by adults and the people around you. If you come from a safe and trustworthy environment, your personality

develops the way it should. My parents and the adults around us never wanted us to depend on them. Many people give back to society what they received from the society where they spent their childhood. I am fortunate to have come from a place where I was given the care and respect one deserves to have as a child. This doesn't mean that I didn't face any challenges. But I could successfully challenge the challenges that I came across, thanks to how things went around me.

My parents and teachers were able to identify my talents. I was encouraged to improve and polish them. I was given opportunities to showcase my talents. I was an assistant head prefect at my school. I could write a story of gratitude about the contributions of people for the betterment of my life. Therefore, the first nineteen years of my life contributed immensely to the adult I am and what I am today.

Q: When you're talking of this 'thinking to myself', since we are from an undergraduate background, from the degree program B.Sc. in Management & IT, there comes a point in every student's life that one should be able to understand or come to the realization of what that person needs to do in their lives. For example, if they have to choose a career path like you said, there is this position that every person comes into, which is that having to choose just one job is not their cup of tea. So, for you to be a writer, you have taken this position. How did you make that choice? How did you recognize that this is the field for me?

Sometimes one is directed towards the right path very early, while for others, it takes time. To facilitate early direction, a country must possess a robust education system with an updated syllabus, incorporating new subjects that are in demand. I grew up in a time when there was no career guidance or counseling, and the Internet did not exist. The world seemed small, and the available options appeared limited.

I have had a love for reading since my childhood; I was able to read books by the age of 4. I wrote my first poem at the age of 7, and my work began regularly appearing in newspapers. However, I didn't know how to become a writer, mainly because there was no defined career path as a "writer" at that time. We were only aware of a few respectable professions like doctor, lawyer, teacher, engineer, nurse, and banker. The concept of being an entrepreneur did not exist, and only a few subject streams were available.

In such a situation, one is expected to find their way or create their path. These paths can be forged through the choices you make. With proper guidance and support, one can start early, which is fortunate.

As I mentioned earlier, I had the habit of working committedly and joyfully in everything assigned to me. Even if I had to do things I wasn't particularly fond of, I chose to work joyfully. Finding joy in everything you do makes the journey easier. While I didn't know what I truly wanted to be, I initially thought of becoming a psychiatrist, so I pursued Biological Science at my Advanced Level. However, I didn't obtain enough marks to enter medical college, and instead of trying my luck again, I chose to become a teacher.

I taught my students to the best of my abilities, going the extra mile to prepare additional learning materials, which eventually turned into a book. When you approach things with sincerity, you are blessed and assisted

generously by the universe. Though I never initially aspired to be an entrepreneur, looking back, I recall a desire to own my school where I could create a better syllabus. The desire to be a published author led me to become a publisher, a startup co-founder, and ultimately a CEO.

My advice to undergraduates is that if you are not certain about what you truly want, try different things. Start as early as possible, but give yourself enough time. Discovering what's meant for you can take time. Remember, everything depends on your choices. So, no matter what you do, choose to be happy and peaceful. This way, you will be able to excel in everything you do, irrespective of the difficulty level.

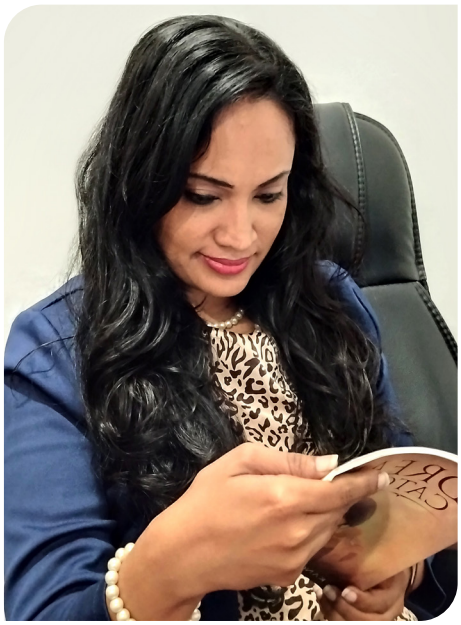
Q: Like you said, the educational background of any person is very important. It's not the traditional educational background that one must possess, but sometimes it's common sense. It's the social sense one person must have within themselves. If I'm not mistaken, your school was Sri Sumangala Girls' School in Panadura. And you also went to the Open University of Sri Lanka. So, can you explain how those experiences and those academic backgrounds led you to become the person you are today?

There are three types of education: formal, informal, and non-formal. Academic qualifications can be achieved through formal and non-formal education, playing a crucial role if you are associated with a relevant industry.

I have observed that sometimes people celebrate those who couldn't complete their higher education. Unfortunately, what these individuals celebrate is their absence of academic qualifications. What should be celebrated is what they have done or achieved through hard work and self-learning. There is nothing wrong with having academic qualifications. It indicates that you have academically studied what's relevant to the career you are pursuing, enabling you to easily adapt to your chosen field because you understand the underlying theories.

Academic qualifications obtained from a country like Sri Lanka can be an indicator of a good memory, proficiency in following instructions, and fine comprehension abilities. It may also reflect that you performed well in the past, showcasing qualities like being goal-oriented, focused, and determined.

It's essential to remember that knowledge without practice is useless, while practice without knowledge is dangerous. This is evident in the current financial crisis, where decisions related to the country's finances were made by individuals lacking



knowledge. Being knowledgeable is valuable. However, collecting academic qualifications solely for the sake of accumulation is not advisable.

Personally, everything I have learned has been practically applied. Another aspect to consider is that the right academic qualifications can serve as a confidence booster. When you are confident in what you do, others also gain confidence in your abilities. This helps build trust and confidence in others about your skills. As undergraduates, make completing your degree a top priority because you never know how it might prove helpful in the future.

Q: Let's delve into your career as a full-time writer, and you may be even familiar with the short story series 'Dream Catchers,' which received national acknowledgment as well. So how was this book reached by the critique? What was the feedback from your beloved readers or your fans?

'Dream Catchers' won the Godage National Literary Awards in 2019 and was shortlisted for the State Literary Awards in the same year. The stories in 'Dream Catchers' have been translated into Tamil and Nepali. I believe this sums up the answer to your question.

Q: Diving into your entrepreneurial journey because you are not only a writer, you are not only an educator, and you are also into the entrepreneurial sector, as one should do these days. So as a co-founder and CEO of both KReader.lk and KBOOKS, could you briefly tell us the opportunities and also the challenges that you faced and are facing right now in this business?

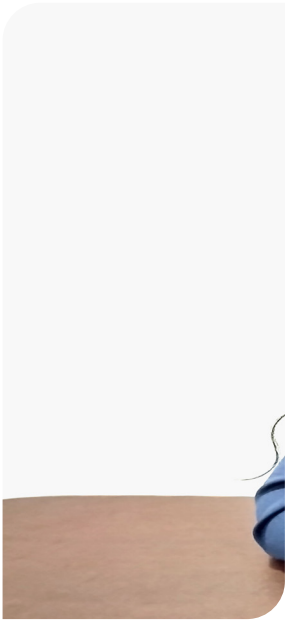
Our ventures are completely bootstrapped. Being an entrepreneur means facing challenges and challenging challenges, making them the new normal. One of the challenges we encountered at the very early stage of our business was breaking the habit of having a strong emotional attachment to the business. When you become too emotionally invested in a business, you tend to take everything personally. It took us around three years to overcome that habit, and it was a true challenge.

If I talk about the current situation, the unreasonable and unhealthy VAT imposed on books, coupled with the impact of the current economic crisis on the lives of readers, has become another challenge for business. In response, KReader, a cross-platform digital reading framework offering both ebooks and audiobooks on a single platform, is a solution we developed to address these challenges. We remain hopeful, so let's see how it unfolds.

Q: Finally, what advice would you offer to undergraduates who are reading this, drawing inspiration from your own life story?

Prioritize completing your degree first. If you don't get to do what you love, learn to love what you do. Never cease learning from the University of 'life'. Never try to become someone else; you never know their complete story. Instead, be unique, and find happiness and joy in everything you do. Be someone responsible. Whatever you are given, make it shine because you worked hard. Don't steal someone else's light; instead, be the light. Most importantly, be politically aware of what's truly going on in the country and cast your vote for people who have the right vision and capacity to rebuild the country. Their decisions will affect your future choices and decisions, so stay awake.

> "Being an entrepreneur means facing and challenging challenges"



INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE ON

SMART COMPUTING AND SYSTEMS ENGINEERING 2023

Keynote Speakers

Dr. Yasantha Rajakarunanayake
Vice President, R&D and AI Technology, Analog Inference, California, United States

Prof. Saman Halgamuge
Professor in Mechanical Engineering, University of Melbourne, Australia

The International Conference on Smart Computing and Systems Engineering (SCSE) 2023, held on the 29th of June 2023, marked its sixth consecutive year. Esteemed delegates from corporate and academic backgrounds, including renowned academics, research scholars, and industry experts, gathered to exchange ideas on recent innovations, emerging trends, and practical challenges in the industrial and service sectors related to Smart Computing and Systems Engineering. The conference received technical sponsorship from the IEEE Sri Lanka Section.

The event commenced with two captivating keynote speeches. Dr. Yasantha Rajakarunanayake, Vice President of Research and AI Technology at Analog Inference, California, United States, delivered an enlightening talk on "Innovation in the Age of Artificial Intelligence". This was followed by a speech on "Machine Learning for Sustainable Energy" by Prof. Saman Halgamuge from the Department of Mechanical Engineering, School of Electrical, Mechanical, and Infrastructure Engineering at the University of Melbourne, Australia. These thought-provoking keynotes set the stage for the subsequent presentations in the technical sessions.

Distinguished guests graced the occasion, including Senior Professor S.R.D. Kalingamudali, Dean of the Faculty of Science and Chairman of the Research Council, Senior Professor Kapila Senavirathne, Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake, Head of the Department of Industrial Management and Conference Chair, Dr. Amila Withanaarachchi. The event was further embellished by the presence of academic and non-academic staff members from the department, researchers, undergraduates from the Department of Industrial Management, and invited guests. Platinum sponsors for the conference were MAS Linea Aqua and SLT Mobitel.

SMART COMPUTING & SYSTEMS ENGINEERING
International Research Conference

SCSE 2023 received an overwhelming response, with 193 full paper submissions from researchers representing countries such as Australia, the United Kingdom, Japan, India, etc. The paper selection process was highly competitive, resulting in an acceptance rate of 29%. All fifty-six accepted full papers will be indexed in SCOPUS and added to IEEE Xplore. There were ten technical sessions after the inaugural ceremony to present papers in two tracks (Smart Computing and Systems Engineering), fostering profound discussions among the attendees.

In conjunction with SCSE 2023, the Department of Industrial Management, Faculty of Science at the University of Kelaniya, organized two pre-conference workshops on the 27th and 28th of June 2023. The first workshop, titled "Transforming Data into Actionable Insights: PowerBI Analytics Workshop," was conducted by Ms. Hiruni Niwunhella, a lecturer at the Department of Industrial Management. The second workshop, led by Mr. Dinesh Asanka, a senior lecturer in the same department, focused on "Data-driven Decision Making: Exploring Analytics and Warehousing Strategies". These workshops witnessed active participation from university academics, data analysts, corporate executives, and graduate students, providing valuable insights into the respective topics.

Organizing Committee

Dr. Amila Withanaarachchi
Conference Chair

Dr. Thilini Mahanama
Conference Secretary

Ms. Yehemini Jayatissa
Assistant Secretary

Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake
Track Chair - Smart Computing

Dr. Shan Jayasinghe
Track Chair - System Engineering

Mr. Dinesh Asanka
Technical Programme Chair

Best Academic Publications

Factors Affecting the Implementation of

Sustainable Practices

in the Sri Lankan Food Retail Sector

Eranga Silva Chathumi Kavirathna

System Engineering Track

Sustainability is becoming a buzzword for today's whole world. To ensure the well-being of the environment, there is a need for immediate as well as strategic action plans regarding sustainability. Companies are looking into ways to lessen their contribution to environmental issues, as well as to reduce the associated high operating costs, using sustainable practices. Their ability to be cost-effective, bring reputation, etc., has been encouraging companies to focus on sustainability implementation. However, a comprehensive study regarding sustainability implementation in the Sri Lankan food retail industry is still missing. This study aims to explore the factors affecting the implementation

of sustainable practices in the Sri Lankan food retail sector by identifying the practices that can be implemented and the factors influencing the implementation of sustainability practices. A literature review identified such practices and the factors in the global context, which were then confirmed for the Sri Lankan context by the industry experts' opinions. Next, a questionnaire survey was carried out to collect empirical data from the food retailers, which was then analyzed using PLS-SEM (Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling). Sustainable practices were identified under three categories: facilities and utilities, internal operations, and market activities, and the influencing factors were identified under five categories: organization and management, economy, regulatory, society, and industry and market. Through the findings, the study emphasizes the need to increase the top management awareness of the various sustainable solutions available, their benefits, and available financing schemes, staff training programs to enhance their knowledge, skills, and attitudes regarding sustainability, having a good functional integration in the firm, and introducing financing schemes to help companies fund sustainable practices.

Smart Computing Track

Integrating Weather Patterns into Machine Learning Models for Improved Electricity Demand Forecasting in Sri Lanka

Shani Abeywickrama P. P. G. Dinesh Asanka

The electricity demand in Sri Lanka is expected to increase steadily over time. Planning for future demand and ensuring an adequate electricity supply poses a significant challenge. It is crucial to accurately forecast future demand to maintain an uninterrupted power supply. Previous studies have explored the correlation between weather factors and electricity demand to accurately predict demand values. Thus, the objective of this study is to forecast the monthly electricity demand in Sri Lanka, by considering the influence of weather patterns. In this study, rainfall, humidity, and temperature weather parameters, along with historical monthly demand data, are taken into consideration. The identification of the most crucial weather variables is based on their correlation with electricity demand data. Various techniques have been employed for forecasting electricity demand over the past decade. However, the limitation of previous studies lies in their failure to incorporate past weather data alongside electricity demand data. This gap is addressed in the present study. This study used Vector Auto Regression (VAR) and Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) models to forecast monthly electricity demand in each district of Sri Lanka. The VAR model demonstrated lower values by comparing the performance metrics, including Root Mean Square Error, Mean Square Error, Mean Absolute Error, and Mean Absolute Percentage Error. As a result, the VAR model was chosen as the most suitable model for forecasting monthly electricity demand by incorporating weather variables.

APPRAISALS

As the Practice Head of Telco Solutions at Axiata Digital Labs, I've had the privilege of engaging with MITians from the Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya. This collaboration has been instrumental in acquiring talented individuals who have significantly contributed to our endeavours in the software industry in the telecommunications and digital services domains.

MITians consistently showcase commendable traits that align perfectly with our company's ethos and the dynamic demands of the industry. Their exposure to a curriculum that seamlessly integrates software engineering and management principles and positive attitude toward learning and contributing to the results have been apparent in their adeptness at navigating complex projects with a unique blend of technical expertise and business acumen.

Our partnership has seen these individuals excel in various roles within our organization, spanning from DevOps Engineers, Software Engineers, and QA Engineers to Business Analysts and Project Managers. Their diligence and hard work have been pivotal in driving innovation and operational excellence, aligning perfectly with ADL's purpose of committing to deliver cutting-edge digital solutions.

What sets MITians apart is not just their technical competence but also their eagerness to learn, adaptability to new technologies, and genuine passion for their craft. Their ability to lead and contribute to critical projects reflects the practical skills instilled by the curriculum of their department and fields of study.

The Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya constantly delivers industry-ready individuals who embody the values of dedication, innovation, and a quest for continuous improvement. We are immensely grateful for the talent pool they've provided us and the seamless integration of these individuals into our diverse teams.

Axiata Digital Labs places great importance on its partnership with the Department of Industrial Management. We look forward to future opportunities to collaborate, aiming to advance innovation, enhance industry benchmarks, and support the joint development of both our organization and the exceptional individuals we work alongside.

Lasitha Jayasiri
Head of Practice - Telco Solutions,
Senior Principal Architect

APPRAISALS

My introduction to the B.Sc. (Hons.) in Management and Information Technology (MIT) undergraduates and graduates occurred during my time at Advantis 3PL. While collaborating on various projects, I was immediately struck by their unique blend of business savvy and technical expertise—qualities that align seamlessly with the demands of Hayleys Advantis 3PL.

A reason why MIT undergraduates stood out at Hayleys Advantis 3PL is due to the management-IT synchronicity. The curriculum's fusion of management principles and technical skills makes undergraduates adept at analyzing problems from diverse angles. Their ability to develop data-driven solutions and communicate effectively resonates in key departments like Marketing, Business Development, Business Systems Solutions, and Logistics Solutions.

At the same time, beyond technical proficiency, MIT undergraduates exhibit an eagerness to learn and adapt, crucial qualities in the dynamic logistics industry and going forward in any industry. Their cross-functional expertise allows them to seamlessly contribute to various teams and projects, enhancing the versatility of our workforce.

The programme's emphasis on analysis instills undergraduates with the ability to interpret data, identify trends, and translate insights into actionable strategies. This analytical acumen proves instrumental in optimizing workflows and making informed decisions in our data-centric environment.

The third-year internship programme provides MIT students with hands-on experience in different fields. This practical exposure equips them to navigate industry challenges, fostering a practical understanding that proves invaluable in our fast-paced environment.

In summary, MIT undergraduates consistently prove to be invaluable contributors to Hayleys Advantis 3PL. Their unique skill set aligns perfectly with our company's needs, and we are continually impressed by their work ethic, adaptability, and hunger for knowledge. The ongoing collaboration between Hayleys Advantis 3PL and the Department of Industrial Management promises to create a mutually beneficial partnership, enhancing both the company and the graduates involved.

Rajika Seneviratne

Head Of Business Development 3PL Sri Lanka

Hayleys Advantis

Annotating the Future: The Journey of Collaborative Plastic Detection Project with the University of Melbourne

Sri Lankan universities often prioritize teaching over research and entrepreneurship for various reasons. Consequently, students tend to focus more on learning content than engaging in research and other activities. This vicious cycle has adversely affected the quality of student profiles in terms of employability. In response, many stakeholders have advocated for involving students in real-world practical projects to enhance their profiles.

The University of Melbourne initiated a project centered on plastic waste management, involving the identification of over 50 types of plastics using robots for separation. To train the system for different types of plastics, the university decided to annotate 1,000,000 objects, a task that posed considerable challenges.

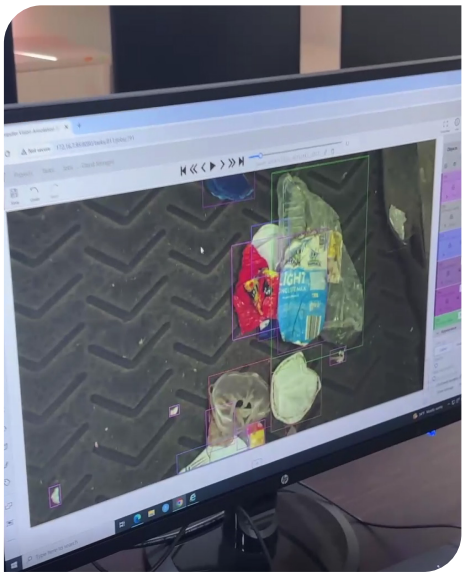
They have invited us to join this research from an annotation perspective, and initially, eleven students participated in this project as a proof-of-concept. The team introduced the concept of annotation and verification to enhance the quality of annotations. Further, the team participated in constructive discussions with the Melbourne team, they extended their support by annotating objects and providing solutions. The success of the initial phase led to an expansion of the team to 40 members, with experienced individuals promoted to leadership roles to oversee the work of new members. This provided them with leadership experience in a real-world project. Additionally, we created the opportunity for all members to become leads on the recommendation and commitment.

Over time, the team found mechanisms for auto-annotating objects, improving the efficiency of the annotation process. This was the technical extension the team added to the project.

Following the initial stage, the next step in the machine learning project is testing the model. The same team performed the model verification by providing the comments and accuracy rates for the auto-annotated datasets. Students had the opportunity to work in the project's data collection and verification processes. By the end of December 2023, the team had completed 540,000 annotations and earned Rs. 2,000,000 as a team.

Key benefits to students:

Despite economic challenges such as scheduled power interruptions, students overcame obstacles and reaped several benefits:



- Engaged in a real-world machine learning project, a rare opportunity for students.
- Recognition for working with a foreign university.
- Contributed to the influx of foreign currency to Sri Lanka which is crucial given the country's current economic state.
- Earned money, allowing students to alleviate their parents' financial burden.
- Obtained teamwork experience by working collaboratively and helping others when required.
- Experienced the satisfaction of participating in a real-world project.

This project is anticipated to expand to various avenues in the future, including software development and research work. These endeavors will empower students to apply both technical and soft skills they have learned over the years.

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I always try to maintain **integrity** and **professionalism** throughout my career, emphasizing the importance of human resources.

Dr. (Eng.) ANANDA HANDUNGE

> “Time management is critical, sometimes I have to work around the clock due to international marketing demands.”

Dr. (Eng.) Ananda Handunge, the Chief Executive Officer at Ferentino Tyres of the Solid Tyre Division, emerges as a dynamic personality with a diverse portfolio and an illustrious career. His journey unfolds in the picturesque city of Kandy, Sri Lanka, where his childhood dreams led him to Dharmaraja College and eventually to the University of Moratuwa. Driven by a commitment to integrity and professionalism, he emphasizes the paramount importance of human resources in any endeavor. Having explored over 25 countries, he continues to hold Kandy close to his heart, attributing its significance to a rich blend of culture and tradition.

With nearly 38 years in the business, Dr. Handunge proudly narrates Sri Lanka’s pivotal role in the global solid tyre market, supplying a remarkable 49% market share. His leadership extends beyond borders, influencing professionals worldwide, particularly in countries such as India,Thailand, Malaysia, and Turkey. Dr. Handunge’s journey reflects a culmination of experiences, from his foundational years in the Sri Lanka Air Force to establishing international brands and leading groundbreaking initiatives in the solid tyre industry. As we delve into his insights, we uncover the strategic prowess and accomplishments that mark his remarkable career.

Q: How would you describe yourself as a person? Before getting into your professional career, how would you explain yourself to another person?

If I explain myself, I always try to maintain integrity and professionalism throughout my career. And what I think of as the most important thing is human resources. We can have very sophisticated machines, equipment, plants, and very good raw materials, but without these human resources, we won't be able to do anything.

Q: If you go back to those days in Kandy, could you explain the pivotal experiences that you had in your childhood that subsequently influenced your professional career?

I made it from Kandy; I completed my primary schooling at the Junior Secondary School of Peradeniya and entered secondary education at Dharmaraja College Kandy. Throughout my childhood, I have dreamed of entering one of the top-tier schools in Kandy, which is Dharmaraja College. I got that chance, upon concluding my GCE (O/L) with great triumph, I was selected as the representative on behalf of the central province for an all-island best student contest of the year in 1978. Then, in 1980, I joined the University of Moratuwa. Frankly, Kandy is my hometown. I have visited a lot of countries across the world, but I still think and feel that my best place is Kandy. Because of not only the geographical factors but also a blend of culture, religion, and everything else.

Q: How is the solid industrial market potential for Sri Lanka?

When we consider the global market, we hold nearly 49% of the market share. To be frank, when you go to any international polymer conference in the US, UK, Germany, or any other country, they call Sri Lanka the capital city of Solid tyres. So, it is understandable that Sri Lanka has a very big position in the said field. All solid tire manufacturers based in Sri Lanka have maintained the highest product quality in the global market.

Q: How has this informed you in a way that helps you in leadership and management positions in the domain?

Yeah, when you consider the West, the Gulf, or any other countries with multi-cultural environments. But most of the professionals who are from Sri Lanka lead the way. Actually, not only that, but they are also doing significant service for their professions in all ways, whether they are in finance, the management field, the medical field, or the engineering field.

Q: You have held many leadership positions in your career, and currently you are working as the CEO of Ferentino Tyres at the Solid Tire Division. How did you get to this position? What kind of challenges did you encounter in your professional career?

Yeah, I can still remember the ability to get through any challenge, which I completely got from the Sri Lanka Air Force. During my basic and advanced training, which spanned 8 years, I got a lot of management and leadership training from there. I am extremely happy to say that in Sri Lanka, I was able to establish two international solid tyre brands in this country. Ferentino Tyre is Sri Lanka's largest tyre plant at present. Ferentino Tyre, a plant of Onyx Group, has invested US$ 250 million, and its plant capacity is set to manufacture 30,000 tons of solid tyres, 10 million pieces of a bias-ply truck tyre, and a whole gamut of products, from radials for light and heavy vehicles to off-the-road (OTR) tyres. Leading tyre manufacturing-related technology provider Marangoni-Italy is the technology partner in the radial tyre project. Ferentino Tyres is Sri Lanka's largest tyre plant at present and is also one of the largest tyre plants in all of South Asia. Being the newest company set up to produce solid tires has been a very challenging job for me. However, the Ferentino Tires were built up to their current status through a systematic approach and careful planning, and they are now a very successful entity.

As the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the solid tyre division, I am responsible for the overall activities of the plant in creating, planning, implementing, and integrating the strategic directions of the organization. This also includes the responsibilities of all components and ensures that the organization's leadership is maintained through constant awareness of the external and internal competitive landscape, opportunities for expansion, customer base market development, new industry developments, standards, and international market development. Furthermore, my responsibilities extend to the entire local and global operations of the company, including activities in production, quality, engineering, financial, safety & environment, human resources, and international marketing having a working strength of 1200 and 120 staff members in Sri Lankan operations including international marketing sectors in USA, Germany, Italy, and France offices.

Q: There must be some motivational factor where you have to get up every morning to come here and do this. What motivates you? What drives you to do this?

Yeah, every day I have a plan. Because every day, I begin with a previous-day plan. I know. Because time management is a critical issue, sometimes I have to

work around the clock because I am involved in a lot of international markets. So, you have to be very time-bound and adaptable. And always, we need to make any kind of goal. I always believe that a can-do' attitude builds up, and nothing impossible can be done despite any setbacks or barriers.

Q: We encountered COVID-19 in the past few years, and we have overcome it now, but we are still facing the consequences, you can say, in various sectors, the economy, and different factors. So, what kind of challenges do you see in the forthcoming years?

Yes, especially with the big challenge of increasing energy costs. Not only the energy cost but also a lot of variable overheads are increasing day by day. Currency fluctuation is also one of the key factors. Finally, I can say that we have very skilled people, very technical people, and the most qualified R&D people in Sri Lanka. The most difficult thing is getting control of variable overheads. That's why, throughout the day, we are dealing with a lot of ways to control it. Not having to view our path, you, from a level point of view, might have to know what variable overhead is.

Q: Could you explain what variable overhead is?

Of course, variable overheads mean if you consider making one product, yeah, there are two things. One is a raw material; the other is a conversion cost. Conversion is included in labor, energy, depreciation, finance costs, and other operational costs. Yes, so even the one that wins has a financial cost because now in Sri Lanka, our interest rates are also high. So, numerous factors can affect those challenges as well. But there are a lot of variable factors, and we are very confident that we know how we are going to work out those situations here.

Q: What were the catalysts that sparked your interest in the field of engineering? And how did your academic journey shape and steer your professional pathway?

Yes. I began pursuing my higher studies in mechanical engineering at the age of sixteen by enrolling in the University of Moratuwa and thus graduating from it in the year 1985. I continued further, then went on to attain an MBA in Total Quality Management from the University of Leicester, UK, one of the highly prestigious universities in the UK, in 2004, and a PhD in Total Quality Management from the UK in 2008. Having received an MSc. (Eng.) in Professional Engineering from the University of Derby, UK, in 2018 I became a Chartered Mechanical Engineer (CEng), thus qualifying as an International Professional Engineer (IntPE) with the Engineering Council of the United Kingdom. "I am also a Certified Management Accountant (CMA) with the Australian Institute of Certified Management Accountants, a member of the Institute of Mechanical Engineers (MIMechE) in the United Kingdom, a member of the Institution of Engineering and Technology (MIET) in the United Kingdom, a Chartered Professional Engineer (CPE), a Chartered Member of Engineering New Zealand (CMEngNZ), a fellow (FCIML), and the President of Chartered Institute of Management and Leadership, USA, and a fellow member of the Institute of Chartered Professional Managers of Sri Lanka (FCPM-SL).

Currently, I am volunteering and holding the following appointments:

- A member of the Advisory Committee for the Ministry of Industry & Commerce
- A member of the Advisory Committee for the Sri Lanka Export Development Board
- A member of the Board Governors, Business Management School, Sri Lanka
- Visiting professor, Ecole Superieure Robet de Sorbon University, France
- International Professional Review Interviewer, Institution of Mechanical Engineers, UK
- An executive committee member: Institution of Engineering & Technology (IET), UK-Sri Lanka chapter

Q: So, I see you as a master of all trades.

Yes, then simultaneously, I became a prominent mechanical engineer in the UK. Then, after that, I became an international professional engineer as well. That is the highest level of engineering profession that I work for.

Q: Most of us have problems managing our time, and that's a very big problem that all of us have. Do you have any secret tips that you want to share?

Yes, I know that the main thing is time management because 24 hours means a very limited amount of time. I always work in my office for nearly 12 hours. After that, I also have discussions with overseas countries.

Q: So, this exposition magazine, happening for the 19th consecutive time, is organized by the undergraduates of the University of Kelaniya. Could you just touch on some of the key advice and key lessons that you would like to share with the undergraduates?

Yeah, I'm extremely happy to share some key advice and key lessons. I think next year they are going to recruit 45,000 undergraduates for government universities in Sri Lanka. My best advice is that in your professional career, soon after you leave the universities, for an initial period of at least four to five years, you're going to be experiencing the same thing. You need to get more practical experience than academics. We have to take on any challenge to maintain professionalism to the highest degree. If your grade is higher than standard dreams, be careful when you take risks.

Tidings

Acknowledging The Accomplishments

Triumphs and Trophies: Academic Maestros

Vice Chancellor's Award Ceremony

The recent Vice Chancellor's Award Ceremony on Research Excellence at the University of Kelaniya showcased the remarkable achievements of the Department of Industrial Management. Dr. Chathumi Kavirathna, senior lecturer at the department, was honored with the "Most Outstanding Young Researcher" Award in the Faculty of Science, affirming the department's commitment. Furthermore, the esteemed department head, Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake, along with the senior lecturers, and Dr. Chathura Rajapakse, were awarded the prestigious Vice Chancellor's Award, signifying their unwavering commitment to the upliftment of academics of the Department and knowledge in their respective fields. These honors highlight the department's dedication to quality as well as its critical role in determining the direction of academic research at the University of Kelaniya in the future.

Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake

Dr. Ruwan Wickramarachchi

Dr. Chathura Rajapakse

Dr. Chathumi Kavirathna

Dr. Thilini Mahanama

Staff Badminton Tournament, University of Kelaniya

Dr. Thilini Mahanama, a current lecturer at the Department of Industrial Management, acquired an impressive victory at the Staff Badminton Tournament, University of Kelaniya. Teaming up with Dr. Kalya Subhasinghe, Dr. Mahanama secured the championship title in the Women's Doubles category. This achievement reflects not only her academic expertise but also her prowess on the badminton court. Their achievement highlights the diverse talents within our university community and underscores the importance of nurturing a well-rounded environment where individuals can thrive both academically and athletically.

Rising Stars: Celebrating Undergraduate Conquests

CODECON 3.0

CODECON 3.0, organized by the IEEE Computer Society of SLIIT, is based on the development of an application considering an innovative idea. The event provides a platform for individuals to showcase their coding and problem solving skills. Participants were tasked with creating and presenting their unique and inventive concepts through the application development process. Chamil Yahampath, Pathum Lakruwan, Sonal Paranawithana, and Anuji Vithana were able to achieve the 4th place of this competition. Their success underscores their proficiency in technical skills and innovative thinking within the domain of application development.

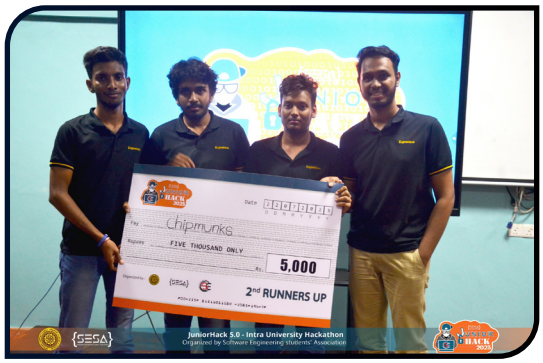
HACKAHOLICS 5.0

Hackaholics 5.0 was an event served as a platform for young women to showcase their innovative ideas and problem solving skills which was organized by, the IEEE WIE Student Branch Affinity Group of University of Colombo School of Computing (UCSC).

Nawoda Jayasinghe, Dilmi Kaushani, and Lakshani Erandika, all level 4 undergraduates of the department achieved the 1st place. Meanwhile Level 2 udergraduates, Mishara Wickramasinghe, Navienya Gayathri, and Shadurceya Vasanthakumar, managed to achieve the 2nd Runner-up title.

UNILEVER SPARKS STUDENT AMBASSADORS

The SPARKS program provides an avenue for undergraduate students to act as a bridge between Unilever and their respective universities, demonstrating their outstanding skills and potential as emerging leaders. This initiative identifies the country's most promising young talents who are committed to making a positive impact through their leadership abilities. Currently, Sonal Paranawithana, a level 2 undergraduate of the Department of Industrial Management, represents the university as a SPARKS ambassador for the years 2023-2024.



JUNIOR HACK 5.0

Junior Hack 5.0, a hackathon which was organized by the Software Engineering Students' Association of the University of Kelaniya focused for young innovative undergraduates with outstanding coding capabilities. The team "Chipmunks" consisting of level 2 undergraduates of the department, Chamil Yahampath, Thamindu Niranjana, Vishath Amarasinghe and Kasun Dananjaya, managed to clinch the 2nd Runner-up title. This achievement demonstrates their expertise in coding and their proficiency for related academic modules.

C.E.O 2.0

Challenge Every Opportunity (C.E.O) organized by AIESEC community of the University of Kelaniya in collaboration with Informatics Institute of Technology and University of Uva Wellassa, was a business case study competition focused on Marketing, Accounting & Finance, Human Resources, and Information Technology. Pavith Rajapaksha, Rajitha Madushan, Dilshan Hettiarachchi, Shamika Tissera and Sajee Rodrigo from level 4 of the department representing team "Zyndicate" emerged as the 2nd Runner-up of C.E.O 2.0. This victory highlights their skills in diverse business domains and their commitment to addressing real world business challenges.

UNIVERSITY OF MORATUWA INTERNATIONAL SHUTTLE FIESTA (UMISF)

The University of Kelaniya badminton team won the title of the championship in University of Moratuwa International Shuttle Fiesta (UMISF). Nihim Abhayarathne, an undergraduate from level 3 and Chathura Dananjaya Fernando, an undergraduate from level 1 of the Department of Industrial Management shone a considerable dedication for the championship. Their remarkable skills were vividly showcased during the thrilling final match, adding to the overall success of the badminton team of the University of Kelaniya.

LAZARUS 2.0

Chamil Yahampath, Sonal Paranawithana, and Pathum Lakruwan, all level 2 undergraduates of the department, achieved the 1st Runner-up position in LAZARUS 2.0 representing their team "Denkers". This ideathon, organized by the "Power and Energy Society" of the IEEE student branch at the Sri Lanka Institute of Information Technology (SLIIT), served as a platform for innovative ideas. The success of team Denkers underlines their creativity and problem-solving skills by contributing to the elevation of the current standings of the department.

UNIVERSITY COLORS AWARDING CERAMONY

The University Colors Night 2023 which was held on 27th of July at the Dharmaloka Hall, University of Kelaniya, was a grand event served as a tribute to the pinnacle of sportsmanship, where the Department of Industrial Management proudly witnessed the recognition of 19 outstanding students through the esteemed Colors awards.

List of colors achievers:

2017 Batch

- Thilina Aluthge - Rugby
- Kisal Perera - Rugby
- Sanjaya Chathuranga - Rugby
- Bashith Piumal - Rugby
- Pamuditha Rajapaksha - Hockey
- Thisal Attygalle - Hockey
- Anushika Samarakoon - Basketball
- Kasintha Kalhara - Basketball
- Lakshan Rasingolla - Taekwondo
- Malinga Herath - Carrom
- Sachini Ginige - Scrabble

2018 batch

- Thushan Dodanwela - Tennis
- Rajitha Madushan -Track & Field
- Pasindu Perera - Hockey

2019 Batch

- Nihim Abhayarathne - Badminton
- Ishan Ravindu - Hockey
- Waruna Sri Wickramasinghe - Hockey
- Racshan Chandrakumar- Basketball

2020 Batch

- Mohamed Rusaik - Football

Among these remarkable recipients, we take special pride in acknowledging the noteworthy achievements of Junior Staff Member, Lihini Kankanamge. Her dedicated commitment to academic excellence, coupled with her stellar performance as a badminton player within the university badminton team, was rightfully honored with a special award.

We extend our heartfelt congratulations to all the recipients, applauding their dedication, passion, and outstanding contributions. These esteemed students relished the glory of the department through their well-deserved achievements.

CODE BLAST NATIONAL HACKATHON 2023

The Code Blast National Hackathon 2023, powered by SLT Mobitel, held on the 30th of September 2023, brought participants together from across the nation to showcase their exceptional talents and innovation in addressing real-world challenges. After intense competition and evaluations, Team Denkers, comprising Chamil Yahampath (Leader), Sonal Paranawithana, Pathum Lakruwan, Vishath Amarasinghe, and Thamindu Premaratne from Level 2 of the Department of Industrial Management of the University of Kelaniya, were able to achieve 1st place. Their outstanding creativity, innovative ideas, and remarkable contribution exemplifies the department's commitment to yield talented undergraduates.

SRI LANKA UNIVERSITY GAMES – 2023

In Sri Lanka University Games (SLUG) 2023, several undergraduates from the department were able to achieve remarkable victories. Enuka Arachchi, a dedicated member of the university rugby team from Level 1, showcased his excellent skills on the field as his contribution led the team to achieve the 1st Runner-up position. Chathura Fernando and Nihim Abhayarathne, from level 1 and level 3, contributed significantly to the success of the badminton team of the university, demonstrating excellent sportsmanship and teamwork on their journey to achieve the 1st Runner-up position in the field of badminton of SLUG 2023. Waruna Sri Wikramasinghe, an outstanding hockey player from level 3, delivered a brilliant performance that led to the University of Kelaniya hockey team clinching the 1st Runner-up position. Their collective achievements highlight the depth of talent within our department and the sports community of the university and have served as inspirations to their peers and the entire university.

BI MASTER 1.0 - 2023

"BI Master 1.0" is an idea-pitching competition organized by the Association of Business and Technology of the University of Kelaniya. The competition aims to encourage undergraduates with innovative business ideas. The level 3 undergraduates of the department, Isal Dias, Manod De Silva, Nihim Abhayarathne, and Raduni De Abrew, represented the victorious team. Their collective brilliance and strategic prowess in BI Master 1.0, not only secured a position but also underscored the department's dedication to fostering excellence in both academia and multifaceted challenges.

ALLIANCE OF MASTERMINDS HACKATHON

Chamil Yahampath, Pathum Lakruwan, Vishath Amarasinghe, Sonal Paranawithana, Kasun Dananjaya, Ishadya Abesighe, and Anuji Vithana, all level 2 undergraduates of the department became the 2nd runner-up at the Alliance of Masterminds Hackathon, organized by Generation Alpha. Demonstrating dedication and teamwork, these undergraduates showcased their skills and commitment as they advanced in this competition representing their team, "Denkers."

NBQSA 2023 – GOLD AWARD

Abishaa Rubanathan, a level 4 undergraduate from the Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya, has been awarded the Gold Award at the 25th National ICT Awards NBQSA 2023, held on October 25, 2023. Her remarkable project, 'Cubic - A Mobile-Based Platform for the Sri Lankan School Transport System', focuses on enhancing the safety of school children. The event, organized by BCS - The Chartered Institute for IT, recognized Abishaa's outstanding contribution in the Tertiary Student Business Category, honoring the most exceptional project undertaken by a tertiary (undergraduate) student or a group of students. Supervised by Dr. Amila Withanaarachchi, senior lecturer at the Department of Industrial Management, University of Kelaniya, Abishaa received the award from President Ranil Wickremesinghe. Abishaa's success stands as a testament to her innovative mindset and dedication to addressing real-world challenges through technological solutions.

HUAWEI ICT COMPETITION 2023-2024

Sri Lanka national HUAWEI ICT competition, organized by Huawei Sri Lanka, is an annual competition which provides a platform for undergraduate students all over the country, to demonstrate their ICT proficiency. It is held under two title tracks of Network Track and Cloud Track. Tharuka Sandaruwan, a level 3 undergraduate of Department of Industrial Management achieved the 1st Runner-up title under Cloud Track. Since this competition expands globally all around the world, his achievement has contributed to the elevation of the current standings of the department.

EXPOGENIUS QUEST BY J'PURA EXPO 2023

ExpoGenius Quest is an export-oriented innovation competition, specifically designed for the undergraduates of the state universities in Sri Lanka. The competition provides a platform for the undergraduates to showcase their innovative ideas, solutions and products that have the potential to excel in the international market.

Lasidu Lashan, Pasindu Nadun Induwara, Navindu Rasanjana, Matheesha Herath, and Pramuditha Vidushan, all level 1 undergraduates of the department, were able to achieve the 1st Runner-up title representing their team, "Cyclops". Team Matriarchy, consisting of level 2 undergraduates of the Department, Mishara Wickramasnghe, Navienya Gayathri, and Shadurceya Vasanthakumar, achieved the 2nd Runner-up. This success reflects the outstanding capabilities and innovative spirit of these talented undergraduates.

SRI LANKA UNIVERSITY COLORS

Ishan Ravindu, a level 3 undergraduate in the Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya, is a distinguished member of the hockey team of the university. As an exceptional sports enthusiast, he has garnered numerous achievements, significantly contributing to the department's success in sports. Notably, Ishan was awarded Colors in Hockey at the prize giving ceremony organized by the Sri Lanka Universities Sports Association.

Ishan Ravindu

POWER UP '23

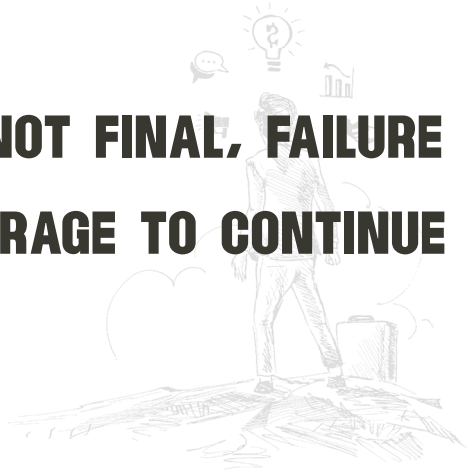
Power Up '23 organized by IEEE PES of the University of Peradeniya and Sri Lanka Institute of Information Technology (SLIIT) was an innovation related competition which was held under two categories of renewable and non-renewable energy. Shadurceya Vasanthakumar, Chathumini Samarasingha, Mishara Wickramasinghe, and Navienya Gayathri, all level 2 undergraduates of the Department of Industrial Management were the winners of the non-renewable category, representing their team "Matriarchy". This achievement not only highlights their innovative prowess but also underlines the commitment of the department to nurturing talented individuals.

Shadurceya Vasanthakumar

Chathumini Samarasingha

Navienya Gayathri

Mishara Wickramasinghe



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Get Connected

Sadly, it's disconnected

By Pasindu Bhanuka
Level 02

Just two decades ago, the online world looked markedly different. The internet had yet to gain widespread use during that time. Face-to-face communication was paramount, and we relied on shared experiences to forge relationships. Families gathered in front of home televisions, filling the space with laughter and chatter. We savored life's simple pleasures, spending time outdoors, crafting kites, and flying them with friends. Through handwritten letters, SMS, and cherished in-person encounters, we nurtured our connections.

However, the introduction of smartphones caused a significant shift in our world. These gadgets provided connectivity and convenience but also had some unwanted side effects. Family members began to drift apart in many homes. The younger generation lost themselves in video games, communicating with friends virtually rather than in person. Moms watched YouTube videos while making dinner, and sisters became engrossed in the allure of TikTok, where they garnered attention from online followers. The once close-knit family started disintegrating as each member sought refuge in their digital cocoon. There was a change in relationship dynamics as well. In the past, a young boy would summon the courage to approach a girl directly and make the first move in a relationship. However, as things have changed, so has the process of making connections. Nowadays, the procedure often begins with a boy seeking a girl's phone number and initiating contact through text or social media. While this approach may seem more practical, it can occasionally harm a person's self-confidence. In the unfortunate event of a separation, the connectedness of today's society can also result in the online exposure of private matters, widening the emotional chasm.

Our friendships significantly impact our lives, and the internet era has made it simpler than ever to find new friends without being limited by distance. The irony, however, is that when friends gather in person, they often find themselves engrossed in their digital gadgets, capturing moments with smartphones and promptly sharing them on social media platforms like Facebook and Instagram. Some people continue online conversations with others even while engaged in face-to-face discussions, undermining the depth of their in-person interactions, and fostering an uneasy sense of alienation.

When I remember my youth, I cherish playing cricket with pals. However, with the advent of cell phones, a new era emerged where youngsters predominantly engage in online games. Even if they do not know the kid living next door, they form relationships with peers from other places through the online gaming community. Unfortunately, social media and online games may lead kids to participate in problematic behaviors, further distancing them from their parents. Consequently, they might struggle to comprehend the depth of parental love, sacrifice, and protection.

Personally, I face similar challenges as an individual who is genuinely passionate about technology. How can I navigate this situation successfully? Realistically, eliminating social media from our lives is impractical, given its deep integration into contemporary society. Setting boundaries remains a sensible and workable strategy. I identify the unnecessary social media networks through self-reflection. By identifying and deleting those accounts, I may limit myself to just two or three personal social media identities, serving as platforms for sincere connections and meaningful dialogue.

There are numerous opportunities worldwide to connect with people who share your interests and foster lasting relationships. Joining clubs and participating in activities like charity work are excellent ways to reestablish contact with real people. Beyond the evident health benefits, sports promote enjoyment, awareness, and positivity, making it possible to forge long-lasting connections. They also provide a space for physical engagement.

My body, mind, and spirit can all achieve balance through meditation, a peaceful and uncomplicated discipline. It promotes mental health, sharper attention, and inner tranquility. By dedicating time each day to device-free meditation, I can break free from the allure of social media and cultivate mindfulness. As a result, this mental fortitude strengthens relationships with people and establishes me as a more sympathetic and well-respected person.

I can decide in advance to spend my free time on things that encourage real connections. I consciously choose to use my phone less, opting not to go live on Facebook or listen to music alone when traveling. This deliberate choice enables me to improve my attentiveness and generate enduring memories. When I eventually return to my routine, I feel revitalized and remember how important it is to have these genuine connections with the people in my life.

Outdoor games and artistic crafts, such as constructing kites, Vesak lanterns, and other season-related items, can occupy children's leisure time. These activities encourage cooperation, leadership, and creativity, positively impacting their general development and potentially enhancing their school performance.

The world is changing rapidly, and as we strive to adapt to these changes, it is essential to take a moment to consider their implications. Many people grapple with waning self-assurance, increasing busyness, and a need for meaningful connections. Due to a lack of companions to confide in, some individuals may even experience depression. Such emotional difficulties may also lead to severe consequences like suicidal ideation. Always remember the importance of forging genuine bonds with people in the real world, expressing love, and caring for others. By disconnecting from the virtual world, we can appreciate the beauty within and outside of us while pursuing more significant goals.

Mr. Pasindu Bhanuka
Level 02,
Department of Industrial Management,
University of Kelaniya.

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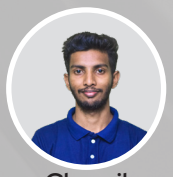
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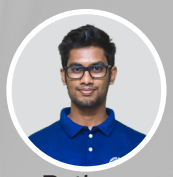
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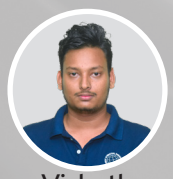
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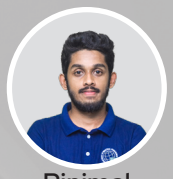
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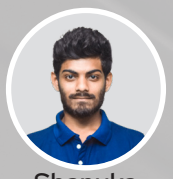
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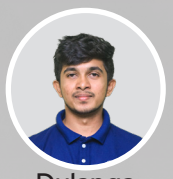
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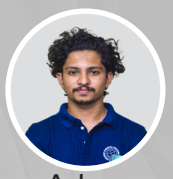
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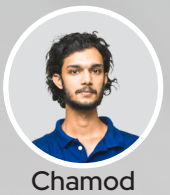
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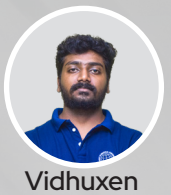
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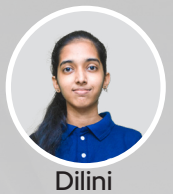
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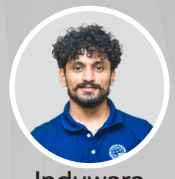
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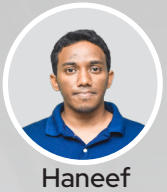
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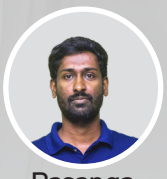
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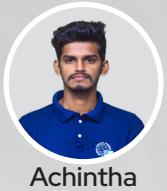
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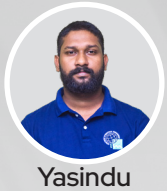
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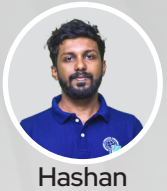
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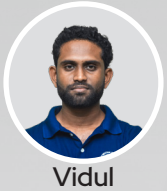
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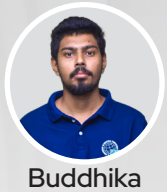
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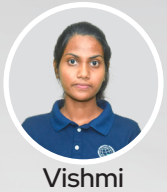
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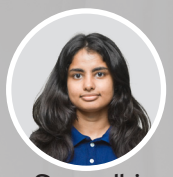
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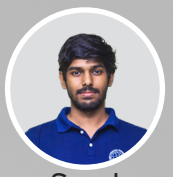
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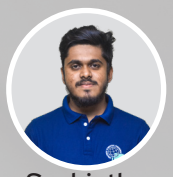
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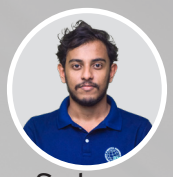
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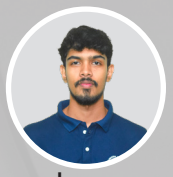
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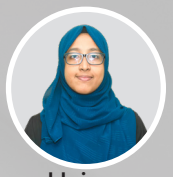
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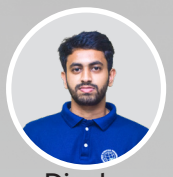
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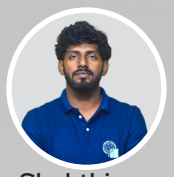
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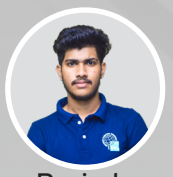
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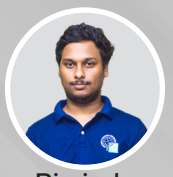
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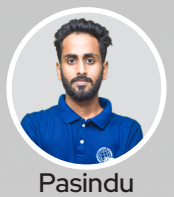
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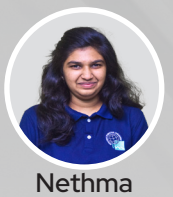
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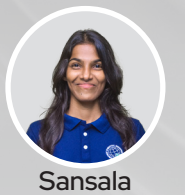
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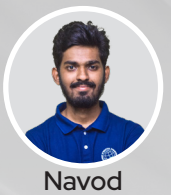
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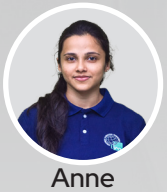
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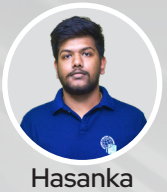
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